

Edible Landscapes: Food as an Artistic Medium

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Abstract

Food is a profoundly sensorial experience, as it nourishes us, it also gives us meaning and makes us what we are. Memories from home abound every time we distinguish the scent of our favorite foods or when we attempt to recreate cherished recipes from home that only our mother knows how to make. Food carries personal stories that can be experienced through the embodied act of cooking and through sharing food with others. Food can also be art, because it needs to be appreciated and digested, not only through the sense of taste.

This master's thesis investigates food as an artistic medium, materializing memories and my personal identity into edible art in the context of leaving my home country of Mexico to establish in Finland. This research is driven by a contemporary emerging and exciting cross-disciplinary sphere between food, art, and design, and proposes a whole artistic practice out of this ephemeral and multidisciplinary medium.

The first part of the thesis provides a theoretical framework that builds a comprehensive backdrop around my food culture, personal identity, the realm of the senses, and the intersection between food and art. food. By delving into the personal, cultural, sensorial, and emotional dimensions of food, this research reveals how it can be used to evoke memories and emotions, and communicate personal narratives. Furthermore, the second part corresponds to the artistic and practical research, which is divided into individual ingredients with cultural, historical, and personal meanings to me. Each ingredient starts from my personal stories, grows into edible experiments to then unravel into an edible landscape. In the artistic research, an experimental exploration of flavors, shapes, and colors is performed through the embodied act of cooking, as well as through the sensuous act of eating.

Keywords: ❁Edible art❁Food❁Food culture❁Food narratives❁ Identity❁Memories❁ Multisensory experience❁

Unless otherwise specified, all photos, illustrations and artworks are of the author's own.



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Contents

8 Food Glossary

10 Introduction
- 10 *Mise en place*
- 14 Research Question
- 15 Structure

16 My Artistic Practice

18 Theoretical Framework

20 Chapter 1: My Food Culture
- 22 Sacred Maize
- 24 Mexican National Cuisine
- 25 Female Figures in the 'Kitchenspace' and Their *Sazón*
- 28 The Idea of Cooking With Love

30 Chapter 2: Food and Identity
- 32 How is Food Linked to my Identity?
- 34 Memories
- 37 Personal Stories and Food Narratives

38 Chapter 3: Food and the Realm of the Senses
- 40 Digesting the World Through the Senses
- 41 Other Worlds of Senses That Make Sense
- 43 Other Ways of Sensory Knowledge

46 Chapter 4: Food as an Artistic Medium
- 48 Is Food Beautiful?
- 49 Food as a Medium, not Only a Material
- 53 Cooking as an Everyday Artistic Practice
- 53 Contemporary Food Practices

62 Artistic Research

63 Introducing the Ingredients

64 Maize
- 66 *Masa*
- 68 *Desayuno:* A *Tostada* Landscape

72 Cakes
- 74 Where it all Started
- 77 *Queremos Pastel*: A Sensuous act of Remembering

84 Chili
- 86 Salsas
- 86 The National Dish?
- 90 Aromas From Home: Cooking Memories Through Complex Salsas

104 *Sobremesa* (Conclusion)

106 Acknowledgements

108 *Recetario* (Recipes)

114 References

124 Appendix

Food Glossary

This glossary is intended to help the reader through the many food-related terms I use in this research. Since this thesis is centered around my identity, I find it relevant to include words from my food culture, for their translations often fall short in encapsulating their true meaning and significance.

Arroz rojo: Mexican rice made with tomato, onion, and garlic.

Cajeta: A traditional Mexican candy made from goat's milk, like dulce de leche.

Caldo de pollo: Chicken stock.

Carne asada: A Mexican barbecue.

Chapulines: Cooked grasshoppers eaten in certain areas in Mexico.

Chilaquiles: A typical Mexican breakfast dish made with tortillas that are sliced, fried, or toasted and cooked with either a red or green salsa, and with different toppings like crema fresca, queso fresco, avocado, fried eggs, and more.

Chile cascabel: A variety of dried chili.

Chile guajillo: A variety of dried chili.

Crema fresca: A milky cream used in Mexican cuisine that tastes like the French crème fraîche.

Frijoles negros: Fried Mexican beans with onion, garlic, and herbs.

Huaraches: A large maize dough base with savory toppings.

Acuyo: An aromatic herb used in different dishes.

Manchamantel: A type of *mole*, named like that because it stains the tablecloth.

Masa: Maize dough.

Mole: A complex sauce.

Mondongo: A soup made of tripe.

Nopales: Edible cacti.

Pan dulce: A variety of Mexican breads, usually eaten at breakfast time. The breads have different sizes, shapes, and sugar toppings.

Pipian: A sauce made with pumpkin seeds.

Pozole: A traditional Mexican soup made from maize kernels, meat, and different toppings.

Queso fresco: It can refer to many white and soft cheeses used in Mexican cuisine.

Salsa tatemada: A salsa where ingredients are charred.

Sope: A small maize dough base with savory toppings.

Tacos sudados: A specific taco preparation that can have different fillings.

Tamales: A piece of maize dough with savory or sweet fillings, wrapped in a banana leaf or maize husk.

Tepache: A Mexican fermented drink, made with pineapple rinds.

Tomatillo: A green variety of tomato with a distinctive sour flavor.

Tostada: A fried or baked crunchy tortilla.

Zacahuil: A very large tamal wrapped in plantain leaves.

Mise en Place

For as long as I can remember, food has had a very special place in my life and in my personal relationships. My parents have very different professions from mine, sometimes we don't understand each other, but when it comes to food, we always find common ground. From a very young age I was always taught to value food, and to appreciate it. I have been very privileged to always have food on the table, something my parents didn't always have when they were children. Food has been very important for me because it is a special bond that I share with my family. I always coincide in the kitchen with my mom, it is a place where only the two of us engage, where we leave our personal differences aside and only that empathy for cooking, for tasting, for creating something new, for trying a new recipe remains.

Since I was a little girl, my mother always encouraged and supported me to experiment with different cakes and pastries (Figure 1). Experiments that, for example, involved making French macarons in our house that has a room temperature of 35 degrees, where it's almost imposible for meringues to rise. While my father doesn't cook, he loves to eat well and has taught me to never skimp on my food choices. My siblings like me, appreciate food and encourage me to cook for them. They always eat everything I make.



Figure 1
Me making cookies at home

Introduction



Figure 2
Me in my snow white birthday party with snow white piñata.

My most cherished memories are intertwined with food stories, where cooking and sharing have always been a love language. On birthdays, celebrations, or just when I visit my hometown after many months of being away, all my family including uncles, aunts, grandparents, cousins, siblings, and my parents have at least cooked on one occasion something for me. *Mole, pozole, tamales, carne asada*, cakes, all Mexican food related to feasting occasions. In Mexico, just like in many other countries around the world, love plays an important role when cooking, I've always known this. I still remember the cake my *abuelita*[1] made on my 6th birthday. In Mexico, all birthday parties are thematic; the costume, piñata, decorations, even birthday candles are related to the theme of the party (Figure 2). My *abuelita* made me on that occasion a huge princess castle cake, I don't remember how it tasted or what the flavor was, I don't remember who went to my party or if I had fun. But the only thing I do remember is how beautiful the colorful cake looked, a castle sculpture with edible details all over.

[1] *Abuelita* means granny; that's how I called my grandmother.

My personal connection to food is the starting point of this thesis. Sometime in my life I considered studying cooking school just to be dissuaded by the idea that it wasn't something I was truly passionate about. I enjoyed cooking a lot, but always thought of it as a hobby, not an artistic practice due to my lack of professional culinary skills. It was not until recently, that I discovered a world where design, art, and food could come together in an exciting cross disciplinary medium that encourages a whole contemporary artistic practice. In this edible world, memories, and identity can be very meaningful. Seeing how many different artists are leveling up food as an artistic practice without formal culinary training or looking for more experimental ways to interact with food motivates me.

This research aims to link food as an artistic medium with my identity and memories related to cooking and eating. My identity as a Mexican woman living in Finland plays an important part due to the foodscape that surrounds me. Sometimes I feel like I have two different stomachs, one from home and one that accepts the food from the place I live in. My memories and food stories, as well as my context of living in a place far away from home builds up by identity and inspires my practice. For me, food is an important aspect of my identity as it carries strong memories while I craft stories as a contemporary designer. Food can be a very broad subject, just by focusing on individual ingredients they can transport a lot of meaning and narratives through them.

While I miss my family and the flavors from home, I'm also happy in the place where I am right now. I love being a foreigner, I love living in vibrant cities and learning new things. Besides my family inspiring my work, cooking with friends from different places, and living in a country far away in the north has taught me to appreciate my food culture (Figure 3). These intercultural relationships have helped me to differentiate myself from others while at the same time finding similarities with other cultures, something that I was missing out from living in Mexico.

This work has relevance in contemporary research as it navigates across the intersection between art and food, from my non-culinary background of design. My personal identity intertwined with my artistic practice allows me to approach food from a caring lens, where seeds, ingredients, history, culture, and ecologies matter. This interplay between art and food not only opens up a world of possibilities but also intricately engages the senses and evokes profound memories associated with food.



Figure 3
Friends and I eating tacos we made together in my apartment terrace, 2019

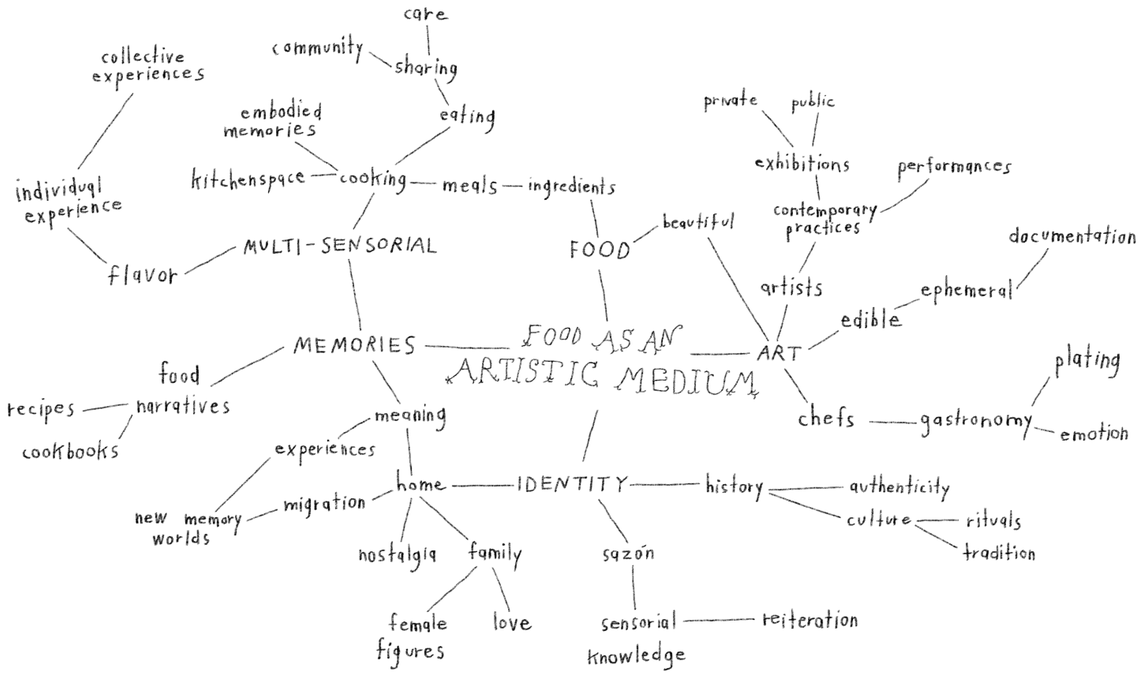


Figure 4
The realm of food as an artistic medium

Research Question

How can I explore food as an artistic medium, using my identity and memories, by contextualizing and experimenting with ingredients and food from my culture?

Structure

The thesis begins by describing my artistic practice as a contemporary designer, to understand where I am situated. Furthermore the thesis is divided in two sections, first the theoretical framework and second the artistic research.

In the theoretical framework a research into my food culture, identity, memories, the senses, and the intersection of food an art will be provided. Chapter one covers Mexican cuisine, *sazón*, cooking with love, and the role of female figures in the kitchen. The next chapter delves into food's connection to identity, memories, and narratives. Another chapter explores the senses, , including synesthesia and intersensoriality. Lastly, it examines food's aesthetics, its use as a creative medium, contemporary cooking practices, food as art, and edible exhibitions.

Afterwards, the artistic research includes my own practice, food narratives and an exploration of essential ingredients within my food culture: maize, cakes, and chili. These ingredients start from memories, and anecdotes, to then unravel into food experiments, artworks and a final installation for each ingredient.

Finally, the conclusion section brings reflections, learnings, and how this thesis wraps up as a whole, including its contribution and future steps. Afterwards, recipes with some of the essential dishes cooked within this thesis serves as a section for preserving and sharing my memories.

My Artistic Practice

I'm a Mexican designer based in Helsinki, currently working in the intersection of art, design, and food. My contemporary practice has taken me in different directions and themes, I have worked on projects that use different mediums such as photography, illustration, wood, ceramic, and biomaterials and exploring topics around the landscapes, memories, and the Anthropocene. However, in this constant search for my own personal identity through my own work, I have found how my contemporary artistic narrative relies on my own experiences and memories, and how I craft narratives that explore care (Figure 5) and togetherness. This carefulness has been present in previous works, including Flourishing Ferments (Figure 6). In this speculative critical design project, I embraced fermentation practices as a caring and nourishing act that allowed for growth in speculative scenarios in post Anthropocene worlds. I nurtured ferments at home, such as kombucha SCOBY and Mexican *tepache*, documenting the journey through diary entries and fictional narratives. This project allowed me to reflect on the caring relationship between human culture and bacterial cultures.



Figure 5
Everything that my Garments have Experienced I have also
Photography project reflecting on my own behavior towards fast fashion consumption and care for items



Figure 7
The Exquisite Disaster of Eating
An experimental carved wooden table and exploration of colors through the messy act of eating tacos

In my artistic practice I draw inspiration from my personal experiences, or from my cultural identity (Figure 7). I do this not because I detest living in another country or identify only as a Mexican woman. Yes, I miss my family and the flavors from home, but at the same time these feelings serve as catalysts for discovering new connections within my practice and remembering ingredients, aromas, dishes, and memories in the kitchen. I incorporate these elements in my practice as I feel comfortable exploring themes and narratives close to me, close to home, that contrast or relate to the context where I currently live and help reconstruct my personal identity.



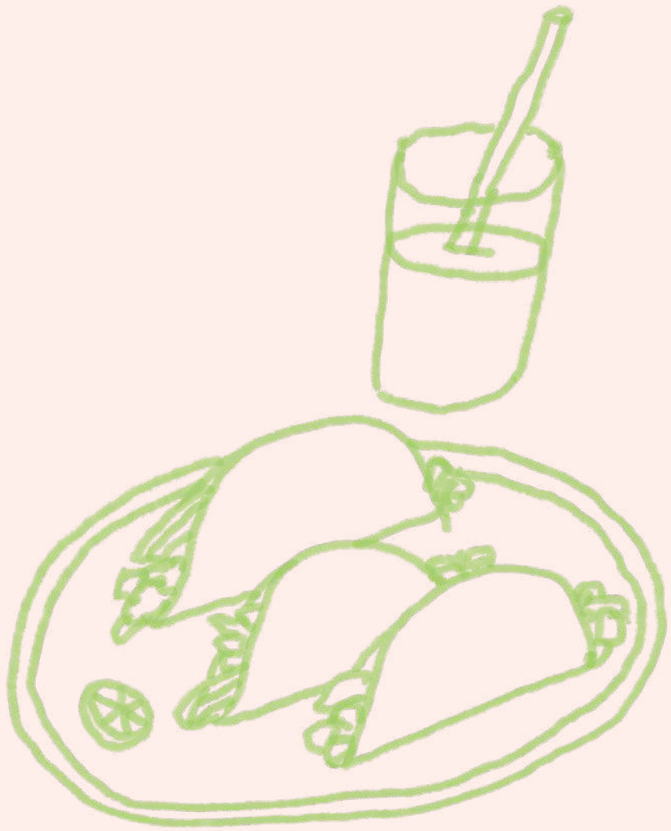
Figure 6
Flourishing Ferments
Screenshot from my online performance

Theoretical Framework



The theoretical framework builds a comprehensive backdrop for a better understanding of the realm of food and art from my own context, intertwined with identity, memories, and the senses. Chapter one will include literature about Mexican cuisine, and *sazón*[2] , as well as the idea of cooking with love and the importance of female figures in the kitchen. In the next chapter, it will investigate how food is linked to identity, its connection with memories, and food narratives. Another chapter will introduce the senses; focusing on taste, starting from a hegemonic western vision to other ways in which different cultures sense the world. This chapter will also present the concept of synesthesia and intersensoriality. Lastly, it will include literature about how food is aesthetic and what it means to use food as a creative medium, furthermore, investigating other contemporary practices around cooking and food as art, and edible exhibitions.

[2] *Sazón* can mean to give flavor to food through your own cooking.



Chapter 1

My Food Culture

This chapter will begin talking about maize, as “we are people of maíz” (Rodríguez, 2014, p. 14). The work of Professor Roberto Rodríguez is of great importance as he examines maize worlds, from its origins to everyday contemporary maize relationships. Rodríguez’s work focuses on elder-youth epistemology, prioritizing maize’s meaning, through a decolonizing perspective. Furthermore, I will include the work of Aguilar-Rodríguez (2018), as it critically examines *mole* and identity, a dish whose complexity goes beyond its flavor. I decided to also include the work of Professor Jeffrey Pilcher (1996, 2001, 2012, 2018) as it carefully investigates Mexican cuisine since pre-Columbian era until recently. His extensive work serves as historical references that can be interweaved with my own experiences around Mexican food.

In the section that examines female figures in the kitchen I will cite the work of Dr. Meredith Abarca, as it is fundamental for understanding the importance of *sazón* and cooking as female agency (Abarca, 2006; Abarca & Colby, 2016). Abarca examines female voices in the kitchen, more specifically, her Mexican mother and her family. Abarca’s research is personal while at the same time political, as she asserts women’s everyday life and knowledge. Finally, I will review concepts related to cooking with love, where I will include the work of Joy Adapon (2008), which builds up on notions from Abarca. They both examine Mexican food and identity from an anthropological feminist perspective, while at the same time interweaving memories, sensory knowledge, and food as art, which is why their work will serve as a relevant backdrop for understanding and digesting the body of work in this thesis.

Sacred Maize

It is tricky to establish the exact origins of Mexican cuisine. This was in part due to the extermination and spiritual colonization attempts by Spain that reduced Indigenous cosmovision, knowledge, and narratives to being evil and satanic (Rodríguez, 2014, p. 46). Pilcher claims that, "Before the conquest, there was no place called Mexico. Linguistic groups such as the Nahuas, Zapotecs, and Mayas, each with their own distinct lands, cultures, and histories, were given the common label of "Indians" in the colony of New Spain[3] " (2012, p. 22). Mexico is a very large territory, whose culture varies depending on the geographic area, encompassing a diversity of people, customs, and traditions. Even so, maize continues to be the basis of food throughout the Mexican Republic. The true origins of Mexican cuisine are still not very accurate because of blurry codices or narrations by Spaniards, telling only their side of the history, where stories don't always align.

In order to trace the origins of Mexican cuisine, it is necessary to start with pre-Hispanic ingredients, which are still the essential basis for today's diet and cuisine. Maize has been a sacred ingredient, fundamental in the construction of Mexicans and their identity (Figure 8). In Mexico, the word for this crop is called *maíz* which is why I prefer to use the term maize as it has more meaning to me. According to Jeffrey M. Pilcher (2001), maize was the basic element in Mesoamerican[4] diets, it consisted on up to 80 percent of their calorie intake. Besides maize, their balanced diet consisted of beans, pumpkin, and chili. At the present time, these four ingredients still constitute the basic and essential elements of Mexican food diets. This can be seen at my home, where there are always tortillas or some other maize food. In the Popol Vuh, the sacred book of the Maya, maize is intermingled with the creation of the universe. In this narrative, maize was used to model humans (Pilcher, 2012). The maize domestication, and consumption was the base for many Mesoamerican cultures, and it allowed them to flourish and create their own cosmovision (Rodríguez, 2014, p. 31). All maize-based cultures had their own different histories of their relationship with the sacred ingredient of maize, which later influenced the creation of different regional cuisines in Mexico. There are several maize dishes around the country, which despite being different, constitute a cuisine whose flavor revolves around maize.

Maize was deeply embedded in indigenous culture; therefore, the culinary colonialism didn't succeed in exterminating the maize crop. Instead, the syncretism of native and

[3] A territorial entity that was colonized by the Spanish Empire between the sixteenth and nineteenth centuries, established mostly around North America.
[4] It is a geographic area in the American continent that includes the southern half of Mexico, the territories of Guatemala, El Salvador, Belize, Honduras, western Nicaragua and Costa Rica.

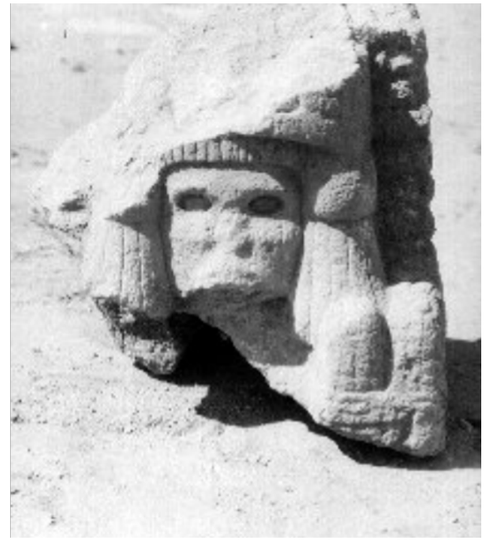


Figure 8
Cinteótl Sculpture
Note. From *Cinteótl, dios del maíz* [Photograph], by Instituto Nacional de Antropología e Historia, México, 1935, (https://mediateca.inah.gob.mx/repositorio/islandora/object/fotografia%3A271375) CC BY 4.0

European food in New Spain gave birth to new flavors and dishes. Certain food elements that came from the "old continent" such as lard, milk, and cheese form an essential part of the most delicious dishes of Mexican cuisine. Spanish and Mesoamerican cuisines mixed, through atrocities of genocide, disease, and a social structure which placed maize as a lower-class staple. According to Pilcher (1996), Spaniards were forced to adapt to Indigenous people's crops and cuisine, since most of the European plants couldn't adapt to the American soils. If it had been for the Spaniards, they would have surely wiped out all the native plants. Pilcher states that, "Conquistadors subsisted on corn tortillas in early years, but not by choice; Bernal Díaz del Castillo referred to his rations as a `misery of maize cakes" (1996, p. 196). Additionally, Spaniards brought cattle and sheep that freely roamed across Mesoamerican soils, eroding it and eating away indigenous crops (Pilcher, 2012). As mentioned before, indigenous people in Mesoamerica worshiped different maize deities and were highly accustomed to maize in their diets. For example, the Aztecs worshipped *Cintéotl* (Figure 5), which meant ripe cob god. The god of maize was one of the main deities Mayan civilizations venerated (Vela, 2011). Thanks to this, the introduction of flour based foods in Mesoamerican diets didn't work completely, only in some exceptions among *mestizos* and *criollos* (Pilcher, 1996).

Mestizos was the label for children born in Mexico from a European and an Indigenous parent. While *criollos* corresponded to the label for Europeans born in Mexico. As Pilcher suggests, "Priests worked to introduce bread during religious festivals, but sacrificial loaves often sat beside *tamales*, indicating continued veneration for maize" (Pilcher, 1996, p. 199). This utmost savagery encounter between both cultures forced indigenous cul-

tures to incorporate Western spices and ingredients, some of which came from European colonization in other parts of the world. Maize remained the primary source of daily survival in rural communities, and cooks in bigger cities incorporated European ingredients, without abandoning the maize and chili in their dishes.

Mexican National Cuisine



Figure 9
Ingredients within a Mole
Note. From El Mole [Paiting], F. Bernal del Río, 1967, Museo Nacional de Arte INBA. (https://www.facebook.com/photo/?fbid=595969789243293&set=a.548030754037197&paipv=0&eav=AfZIZQQQynz3ciZO-n71r-t95rQuYYYW8T47vf-bSzCAPYfuBnoaGhinluL3zwX7Mi8M&_rdr)

After the colonial period, a process of creating a consolidated Mexican national cuisine began. One food example that helped accomplish this process was the *mole* (Figure 8). This dish is a complex sauce, that cannot exist without the chili ingredient. Its complexity derives from its meaning, history, and ingredients. A *mole* can contain the following ingredients, if not more or less: lard, *chile mulato, chile pasilla, chile ancho* (Mexican dried chilis), chicken stock, almonds, peanuts, pumpkin seeds, sesame seeds, tomato, plantain, raisins, cloves, cumin, anis, cinnamon, thyme, oregano, garlic, onion, salt, bread, tortillas, dark chocolate (Figure 9). According to Aguilar-Rodríguez, *Mole* was elevated from being a peasant meal to a refined one, meant for celebrations and a symbol of Mexican national cuisine (2018). The origins of this dish vary according to different authors (Pilcher, 2012); it is a dish that mixes indigenous and European ingredients. It was only after the Mexican revolution that the *mole* became a dish of a higher-status, this in part thanks to the writing of several male writers that crafted a narrative around it (Aguilar-Rodríguez, 2018). When the *mole* became popular, other ethnic groups that contributed to the creation of Mexican culture were marginalized (2018).

Aguilar-Rodríguez argues that in the context of modern colonialism, the discourse of *mestizaje* was introduced among indigenous people as a way to romanticize the imposition of European culture (2018). *Mestizaje* was the biological and cultural mixing between Spaniards and Indigenous people. As Aguilar-Rodríguez attests, "The rhetoric of *mestizaje* honored and recognized pre-Columbian civilizations while disparaging contemporary indigenous peoples because they were seen as lazy, filthy, and ignorant, while their cultural practices had no value" (2018, p. 615). This meant building up a national identity by embracing western culture and marginalizing indigenous people.

Female Figures in the 'kitchenspace'[5] and their *Sazón*

Home cooking has always been related to female tasks, while men are usually acclaimed in professional kitchens. In Mexican *fondas*[6] , women usually prepare and sell homemade food, while *taquerías*[7] generally serve tacos made by men. Viqueira and Alcalá conducted a study in 1984 to find out why it was always that women made quesadillas and men made tacos. They argue that undoubtfully food preparation is more related to female tasks, specifically making the tortillas. In this patriarchal thinking women take the *masa* and gently transform it into tortillas, men on the other hand cook with already made tortillas, more processed food, and in a more "civilized" way (Viqueira & Alcalá, 1984, p. 95). Even now, while my dad helps my mom in the kitchen at times, I've never seen him make homemade tortillas, or spend hours preparing food.

Back at home, the kitchen is my mom's territory. My mother's name is Patricia; however, I never call her by her given name. Even though I help her out to clean beans, chop tomatoes, or press down tortillas, the kitchen is hers. Shortly after marrying my dad, she stopped working as a lawyer and dedicated her time to the home care. Staying at home included cooking all the meals, something my mom didn't like to do when she was younger. However, it did become an enjoyment for her to prepare certain foods that were a pleasure for others. She learned to love cooking because it was a demonstration of affection and love for her children. When I asked my mom what she thought of her own kitchen, she told me *"La mayor parte de mi vida la he pasado en la cocina porque es lo más importante en una familia. Es el punto de convivencia con mis hijos, el punto en el que coincidíamos para comer algo"*. (I have spent most of my life in the kitchen because it is the most important place in a family. It is the point of coexistence with my children, the point where we would meet to have something to eat). Christie argues that for wom-

[5] A term coined by Christie, 2008.
[6] Places that sell homemade style food.
[7] Places that sell tacos.

en, the kitchen serves as a space where they repeatedly tell stories around food to their children, other women, and maybe even to themselves. Kitchens are gendered spaces where individual women reclaim authority over their surroundings. Like my mother, women spend a lifetime in the kitchen, thus making it their workspace, creating narratives around food and passing their knowledge to their children.

My mom learned to cook from my grandmother, therefore I learned to cook from my mom. Even though my mom was taught in a certain way, she has applied her own criteria. For example, she has refused to use stock cubes in her kitchen, something that my grandmother used constantly and that many kitchens in Mexico also use. Other customs that my mom has omitted is the use of lard in food preparation or avoiding the use of *Maseca*[8]. I love my mom's cooking, it is based on fresh and seasonal ingredients that she gets every week from her trusted farmers, and also on looking for alternatives to sugars and processed flours. The motivation behind my mom's food choices come from a support to local farmers in our neighborhood, healthier food choices and opposition to multinational companies. By constantly accompanying my mother in the kitchen, I have learned to cook, and her habits have influenced my food choices, which enrich my way of cooking and what I eat.

Women assert their own agency through cooking and writing about food. In post-colonial Mexico, women played a significant role in writing cookbooks that helped construct a unified national identity (Aguilar-Rodríguez, 2018). Meredith Abarca quotes her mother as she asserts her agency of having her own space to cook:

> In her small adobe kitchen she experienced freedom from having to share the kitchen with a mother-in-law and sisters-in-law; she was generally in control of not only when but also how things were done, to the point that she designed and built her own chimenea [wood burning stove] (2006, p. 22)

Just like Abarca's mother, there are many other stories of female empowerment through cooking. My *abuelita* Nely (Figure 10) has told me before how she sold *tacos sudados* and *mondongo* in my grandfather's workplace. Nely washed, prepared, cooked, and cleaned everything, while my grandfather sold it. She told me she was excited about it because of her love for cooking and because all the money earned was for herself. Nowadays at my grandparents' house, my *abuelita* still takes care of the cooking most of the time.

Women make tremendous contributions in the everyday kitchen-space on social, and cultural spheres. Through creativity, female figures have agency when cooking at home.

[8] A multinational maize flour company, which sells low quality, nixtamalized dried flour.

Trubek et al. argue that, "'food agency' is to be empowered to act throughout the course of planning and preparing meals within a particular food environment" (2017, p. 298). In some Mexican households, this food environment translates to harsh equipment conditions without a cooking stove, financial problems, and time constraints.

My *abuelita* Nely told me how she had to cook with firewood at first. Only later my grandfather bought her a petroleum fueled two-burner stove, where she cooked for her 6 children. Besides navigating this context, home cooks employ creativity in the kitchen to create meals that shape and please family tastes (McCabe & Malefyt, 2013). Empowerment through cooking can then mean imagining different dishes, planning meals beforehand, and learning, while simultaneously having to nourish nutritionally an entire family. Following the story of my *abuelita*, her cooking was a source of power, where she prepared homemade food to sell while at the same making the kitchenspace her own and preparing a variety of meals for her family.

In Mexico, being a good cook means having *buen* (good) *sazón*, which can be translated to good seasoning. However, it means more than the spices that go into food. *Sazón* is relevant to my work because it is part of my identity, as it guides my cooking. My mom would praise her mother in law's *sazón*, complementing her on the red rice she perfectly made all the time. When I was younger, I would ask my mom what *sazón* means. She would tell me, either you have it, or you don't. I grew up thinking of *sazón* as a *don* (divine gift) you are born with. *Sazón* can be described as the act of cooking intuitively, using your hands to measure, and your senses to see what is missing in the food. Your body just knows it. I know many people that have this gift, however not all of them make every-



Figure 10
My abuelita Nely and I

thing with *buen sazón*. Some are better in salsas, while others make better rice or stews. *Sazón* is examined thoroughly by Abarca (2006), where she argues about how hard it is to explain as a concept, how a non-trained cook can create a great dish with the simplest ingredients or how women use their senses, including the *sazón* to cook. Because *sazón* is an embodied act, it is hard to define but it is something that every Mexican person is aware of.

You cannot be a hundred percent sure if you have buen *sazón* or not. When asking my *abuelita* Nely if she had *buen sazón* she told me *"Yo creo que si"* (I believe so). You might think you have it because people finish your food or compliment you about it, but modesty plays a big role in this situation. Most of the people I know don't brag about their *buen sazón*, but I know they have it. As Meredith Abarca tells us about her mother, "Esperanza Vélez's self-assertiveness reflects her own belief in the ability of her *sazón*. The culinary authority she derives from her *sazón* comes from years of recognition of her gastronomical talent, a recognition she receives from family and friends" (2006, p. 53). You must be confident about your own *sazón*, and this only comes from experience, cooking to yourself or cooking to people you care about. This mutual caring and sharing ways of cooking nurtures the idea of your *sazón*. Just as my mother praises my *abuelita's* ability to cook rice, so does my *abuelita* with her compliments towards my mom's *mole*. My *abuelita* and my mom's cooking motivates me to keep learning and developing my own embodied cooking, which is acquired through the years. As I prepare ingredients, mix them, make different Mexican dishes, and feed my memories, I hope that the flavors from home come out through my own *sazón*.

The Idea of Cooking with Love and Other Emotions

Besides the *sazón* being directly connected to a "sensory epistemology" (Abarca, 2006) it is also linked to the "flavour of love" (Adapon, 2008, p. 37). I remember asking my mom how she cooked such delicious dishes, I was hoping she would reveal a secret, but she simply replied, "Es que lo hice con amor" (I made it with love). I grew up thinking of cooking as a love language. If someone is sick, I think of making them a warm wholesome soup. On my mother's birthday, I wake up very early and cook her breakfast. Whenever I'm invited to a birthday party, I always think about bringing a cake. If I'm invited to a friend's house, I try to consistently bring some homemade food. I constantly communicate through cooking, through this universal language of sharing food.

This idea of cooking with love is represented in Laura Esquivel's novel and later translated into a film. Como Agua para Chocolate (Esquivel, 1992), where Tita, the main character transmits her feelings to everything she cooks in this magic realism novel. Tita being the youngest of her family takes charge of all the house cooking, due to patriarchal/matriarchal traditions in that age. Tita had been in the kitchen since she was a baby, thus she learned how to cook through her different senses when being in the company of Nacha, the indigenous cook of the family. Tita continuously expressed her feelings through her cooking. Her sister was getting married to the man she loved, and Tita as the family cook had to prepare the party banquet. While making the wedding cake, she can't control her feelings and tears come down her face into the cake. Afterwards, when the guests try her cake, they all start feeling extremely melancholic and longing for the love of their life. Esquivel clearly exaggerates how feelings go into the food in her literary fiction, but on the other hand it represents how strong we connect our feelings to preparing and cooking in Mexican cuisine. If the salsa turns out too spicy, it is because the cook was angry but if the food turns delicious then the person cooking it made it with love for us.

Cooking something for someone takes a lot of time and effort, especially if talking about Mexican food, as most dishes are quite elaborated. This energy that is being put into cooking can then express your love for the person you are cooking for (Thrussell, 2016). While I can't always express my feelings with words, I believe that they flow through my hands into my cooking. Adding my own personal twist to recipes, using my own *sazón* and originality to prepare and make the food is a way to have agency through cooking. I reflect my own identity and skills in the dishes I make, that intermingle with flavors representing my emotions in a certain moment (Thrussell, 2016). Even though the dishes are elaborated and take time, they are still prepared as they are part of our collective identity.

Cooking with love can mean many different things, from the way ingredients are handled, knowing where these ingredients come from and how valuable they are, how much attention, patience and care you put on a recipe or being aware of the origins and context of the food you are making (Thrussell, 2016, p. 196). Every time my mom cooks *mole*, I see all the amount of love she puts in it. She goes to the store to get all the different seeds, chilis, and spices. She calls her friend, who sells chickens from her farm to put one aside for her. She spends all morning making the *mole*, which involves washing, cutting, toasting and blending the ingredients. And separately cooking the chicken to make *caldo de pollo* and *arroz rojo*, which accompanies the *mole*. I know how much effort it goes into this dish, and how special it is to make it and eat it. My mother's *mole* tastes so good, we all thank her, and compliment her *buen sazón.*

Food & Identity



Last year my parents sent me a food package that made me excited, it contained different foods such as crunchy *chapulines*, *mole*, and chocolate. I immediately thought of sharing the food with my friends, *chapulines* (grasshoppers) being strange but very tasty. When I offered those *chapulines*, most of my European friends made very similar expressions of amazement, disgust, or a bit terrified after their unfamiliarity with this food. Spicy and fried *chapulines* are a big marker of identity as eating them differentiates me from others and these foods are mainly only eaten by Mexicans (Thrussell, 2016, p. 100). I see my personal identity as a mash of many different things, but without a doubt I have always linked food to my identity, where food has been a way to make sense of who I am and a way to connect with others.

How is Food Linked to my Identity?

When I left Mexico to come to Finland, I didn't pack any food from home except some snacks as I still felt safe and nurtured by eating my mother's food at home. I look back and think about how I took for granted the availability of ingredients and home cooking. It was only until I was abroad, displaced, in a new country with food so different from home that I realized the mistake I had made. Now that I live in Finland, I think more about the food I make, how to reproduce tastes from home, how I can swap some ingredients for others; trying to remember food memories, good or bad and sharing all this with the people around me. Is it that I feel more Mexican when I'm abroad, longing for tastes and smells from home, cooking Mexican food to connect to this part of my identity, while at the same time trying to differentiate myself from others. Vincent argues that "you can't be ethnic unless there is someone next to you who is different from you culturally" (Vincent, 1974, as cited in Mintz 2015, p.519). A few months after moving to Finland I regretted not packing enough dry chilis, *cajeta* candies, or *frijoles negros*.

My body of work in this thesis comes from my cultural identity and memories from home, which is why it is important to establish the relationship that exists within these notions. Identity is a very broad term; you can't be right or wrong about it as there's different perspectives and nuances into the word. I would start by asking myself "Who am I?" How do you answer to this question? How do other people around me such as my parents answer this? James D. Fearon defines social identity as the answer to this first question. The definition of identity includes properties and qualities essential to our persona (1999, pp. 12–13). However, when he mentions what personal identity means, he explains the trouble around denying which things are relevant to these fundamental aspects of a person. Hekman defines identity to be a play of two opposites: sameness and difference (1999). She explains how identity is a paradigm in which you try to be unique and different into that collective sameness inside of your community. Or as Richard Jenkins explains better, "We cannot have one without the other: to identify something as an A is to assert that it has certain properties in common with all other As, and that it differs from Bs, Cs and so on" (2008, p. 22). Besides these definitions of identity there exist multiple more, none more important than the other. One thing can be constant, our identity is fluid and it's in constant change, building up from past experiences. In this chapter I will focus on the link between food and identity, how food can define our identity and can help us identify with a larger group of people.

Food and identity are intertwined, what we eat can define us. *"Eres lo que Comes"* this modern quote derives from Brillat-Savarin aphorism: "Tell me what you eat and I will tell you who you are". Food is essential for our everyday lives, and we often forget about how important it is. We all must nourish our body with food at some point, just like water, these two elements constitute our human body. From this point of view, everything we ingest forms part of ourselves, as it breaks down and becomes embodied (Thrussell, 2016, p. 11). Nonetheless, food serves for much more than just maintaining us alive, we cannot use food only for nutritional and statistical purposes (Marak, 2014, p. 99). It is through food that we build and form relationships, that we create habits that continually shape our identity and culture. Before I mentioned how Hekman defines identity as the play of two concepts: sameness and difference. These two opposites translate to food in the way of how food is consumed, and rituals related to this consumption.

Food has been used to convey group affiliations and differences through a variety of different means, including forms, locations, timing, organization, symbolic, and linguistic associations, as well as food production, preparation, consumption, storage, and discard (Metheny & Beaudry, 2015). The questions of where we acquire these ingredients, the motivations behind our choices, and the recipes we seek to replicate or conceive all contribute to the significance of food. Furthermore, the techniques we use to prepare, cook, and taste our meals demonstrate a creative transformation of components into flavorful dishes. Food profoundly influences not only our dietary preferences but also our culinary practices in terms of what, how, and where we cook.

Memories

Food provides a strong link to our identity but at the same time it is also intertwined with the act of remembering. Food has the power to unravel memories, they flow through the senses and can exist as embodied memories. We all have certain food memories, good or bad, and besides the senses making us reminiscent of taste and place, it also has the power to evoke memories related to much deeper emotions, original identities, ways of life, and communal practices (Allen, 2012; Bajic-Hajdukovic, 2013; Lee, 2022a). Janowski argues that "Food has a role as part of individual histories, with memories of childhood and key events often strongly associated with certain foods and methods of preparation; and on a group level, since food is not uncommonly associated with memories of being part of a group which produces, processes, cooks and/or consumes food together" (2012, p. 176). These childhood memories can help in building up taste and establishing favorite meals, while they are also part of identifying with a bigger group. Collective memories and heritage originate from memories from home, resulting in emotions that transcended space and time (Allen, 2012, p. 151; Bigot, n.d., p. 3; Brulotte et al., 2016, p. 1).

As I have discussed, cooking and eating a meal reflects more than just adding up nutrients to our body, it has different dimensions in which we also add up emotions and memories are made. Memories around where we eat, who do we share the meal with, who prepared it, which ingredients, and where do they come from, all these aspects help shape powerful memories regarding that certain food moment. Food is so powerful as it takes us to a certain moment and context. When I remember the fried tortilla with eggs and tomato my grandmother used to make me, I'm also remembering the smells from my grandmother's kitchen. Even though I have tried replicating this simple dish multiple times, I have never been able to make it like she does. For once because she has her own distinctive *sazón*, and also because I cannot recreate the context of her warm kitchen. When I recreate her comfort dish, I remember how she adds enough oil to the tortilla so it can fry thoroughly, and even though my version of it is not as tasty as hers, I still prepare it, because from the moment I cut the tortilla in tiny pieces to the moment I savor a bite, I remember the many times I ate the dish in my grandmother's kitchen.

When we ingest a meal, sensory and affective qualities of it become embodied experiences (Abarca & Colby, 2016, p. 4). Abarca and Colby (2016) argue that there exist different ways in which memory acts, exemplifying this point with cognitive memories which are defined by remembering ingredients, dishes, or styles of cooking through being in contact with food histories. On the other hand, food memories are made up by repetition and habits of dicing, kneading, baking, serving, or sharing (Abarca & Colby, 2016). This repetitive process later transforms into embodied memories that are intermingled with narratives around food that form a collective memory. Everyday practices in the form of food, memory, and sharing food narratives gives me personal and collective significance that keeps building up my identity.

This intricate connection between food and memories is also a tangled one. Both concepts are quite complex on their own due to the multilayered subject of food alongside with its different subjective cultural meanings, and the different mechanisms within memory can allude to diverse dynamics (Holtzman, 2006, p. 362). In anthropology, this thorny but intriguing connection between food and memories has previously been studied by various scholars and from different points of view. Anthropologist Jon Holtzman (2006) sees gender as a fundamental component in the subject, due to the entanglement of relationships and gender roles with memory, specially how much men depend on women for food. Holtzman views the connection between food and memory as a gateway to explore gender beyond the western notions of women's relationship in the kitchen. Counihan (2010) also explores gender and food in her ethnographical book A Tortilla is Like Life, where she interviews different women living in the Southern San Luis Valley of Colorado to reflect on their memories and the foodscape around them. David Sutton's work has been quite extensive and remarkable in the growing field of food and memories. Sutton (2001) investigates food and diaspora, a process in which we try to remember and reconstruct pieces from home. Anthropologist Bajic-Hajdukovic (2013) research among Serbian migrants sees how food from home is being used by mothers and grandmothers as a medium to keep the memories among the family and their identity and ancestral culture alive. In the pages before, I talked about identity and questioned myself if I felt more Mexican when I'm abroad, when I'm next to someone who has a different culture than myself. Professor Ketu Katrak admitted how food became an essential connection with her homeland, as she narrates"... memory banks about food overflowed only after [she] left India to come to the United States..."(Katrak, 1997 p.270, as cited in Mannur 2010, p.27). Now that I live in Finland, food connects me back to Mexico and my family. Food memories are crucial for diaspora. When people move or travel to a new place, they tend to travel with food, carrying seeds, dough, dried plants, or anything they can get their hands on. These foods are vital for building up a new life with new people around them, and as Janowski points out, these new "marker foods and rituals" come up from such stories around foods from their homelands (2012, p. 177).

We create stories and repeat them, by preparing and consuming certain foods with people that reminds us of a place and by reconstructing the past we project this into

the future (Janowski, 2012). This process of remembering can sometimes feel like nostalgia, nonetheless these memories are sometimes very distant from reality and history as we create them ourselves to imagine new narratives to our identity (Appadurai, 1996; Janowski, 2012). Nostalgia and tradition in the form of the recreation of rituals plays an important part as we make new ways of replicating them in a new context with different elements from the homeland (Hobsbawm, 2012; Janowski, 2012). Nostalgia is a complex emotional reaction that was first defined as the "homesickness caused by geographical distance" (Vignolles & Pichon, 2014, p. 227), as this concept was thoroughly mentioned in ancient books and Greek mythology. However, nostalgia sometimes tends to idealize the past (Mannur, 2009). As Mannur argues, "This desire to feel at home can elicit nostalgia for things that never were" (2009, p. 32) One must then be careful when recollecting memories from the past, and repeating home rituals.

Before I introduced how I cook with my own *sazón*, an embodied act of cooking, using my hands to measure and the senses to see what is missing in the food. As *sazón* is an embodied act, it builds up from previous food memories. Hernandez and Sutton use the term "embodied memory" to explain the knowledge in our bodies that we might not be fully aware of. This knowledge is naturally used while cooking, sometimes as an extension of certain cooking tools or equipment (Hernandez & Sutton, 2003, p. 31). A lot of the embodied memories used when preparing and cooking Mexican cuisine disappeared with the use of modern tools. Nevertheless, these tools still work and are very helpful when preparing time-consuming meals. In Finland, when I make tortillas from *masa*, I prepare the dough with my hands. I add water to the maize flour, a pinch of salt, and mix it all. The amount of water always changes as the room temperature varies. I always know how much water it needs, without measuring it. I know when it is ready, I know it by feeling the dough with my hands. My embodied memories come to play when making tortillas. After making a good *masa*, I let it rest for a bit and then form tiny balls. I have my own tortilla press I brought from Mexico; it was very heavy, but it has been very useful. The tortilla press belonged to my mother, she gave it to me when I first moved away from home as a teenager, and it has never left me since. This tool works as an extension of myself, that functions together with my embodied memories when making thin enough tortillas.

Personal Stories and Food Narratives

Every time a food memory is narrated—in an oral, written, or performative form—the food recalled is reproduced as an embodied experience. In telling what 'we eat', we are showing who 'we are'. Therefore, it is not food that defines our social and cultural subjectivities but the stories we tell about our food practices. In short, food memory, as an embodied sense, has the capacity to season the narratives of our lives. (Abarca & Colby, 2016, p. 7)

Abarca and Colby use the term 'food memory' to embody the sensorial, cultural, and social aspects of food, which functions in an individual level but are part of a collective subjectivity. Food memories are important in a narrated way because they tell a story of our past, but also help in defining every day and future food practices. It is through narratives that we give meaning to our individual and shared encounters and define ourselves.

Food is meaningful and it's also a way for communicating. Besides food memories creating narratives, we have, as Hauck-Lawson states, our own particular 'food voice', "a term that crystallized the dynamic, creative, symbolic, and highly individualized ways that food serves as a channel of communication" (1992, p. 7). Carole Counihan uses a feminist methodology for women's food voices. In her methodology she employs "semi-structured tape-recorded interviews with willing participants, on their beliefs and behaviors surrounding food production, preparation, distribution, and consumption"(2012, p. 174), including women whose voices haven't always been heard. Counihan works with women, giving importance to their experiences and giving them agency through their personal narratives. She highlights voices that have been left apart, unwritten, and not given enough meaning. Women's voices are not always heard outside the kitchen (Christie, 2008), which is why it is relevant to include food-centered narratives. Just like my *abuelita* Nely told me about her empowerment through selling homemade food, more stories need to be shared and told.



The Realm of the Senses

Cooking and eating are both complex, sensuous acts, as we experience food through all our senses. In order to understand how food can be a multisensorial experience, the senses need to be unraveled, providing examples of other sensorial worlds, and ways of sensory knowledge that exist outside of hegemonic ‘world views’.

⁜ Chapter 3 ⁜

Digesting the World Through the Senses

> There is no alternative to experiencing the world, to being endlessly traversed and changed by it. The world is the emanation of a body moving through it. A to-and-from arises between the sensation of things and the sensation of self. Before thought, there is feeling. (Le Breton, 2017, p. 21)

As Le Breton argues, the senses help us make sense of everything we experience. We navigate different sensory universes through our own individual identities that belong to a collective one. We are sensorial beings constantly digesting our surrounding world into a familiar fabric that makes sense to our mind (Le Breton, 2017). Every time we eat something we encounter emotions and sometimes memories. Either if we enjoy the meal or if we secretly hate it, we end up feeling something through our different senses or remember past experiences. In contemporary food studies, an interest around the connection between food and memory through the lens of the senses has increased (Meah & Jackson, 2016). Anthropologist David Sutton's work represents a vast analysis around the intersection of food, memory, and the senses. His work is based from an ethnographic work on the island of Kalymnos, Greece (2001), which will be of help for digesting this chapter. Before tasting something, I eat it with my eyes, I recall memories related to a specific food or meal, I try to remember if I like it, or try to associate its colors and aromas to previous food experiences. Le Breton implies that "Taste, the perception of food in the mouth, is a sensory constellation that blends the aroma of foods with their tactility, temperature, texture, appearance, and odor. Eating is a total sensory act. The mouth acts as a frontier between inside and out. It allows for speaking and breathing but also for tasting. Taste is inseparable from this buccal matrix that blends sensorialities"(2017, pp. 184-185). Food is multi-sensorial. We take in all its flavors while our nose perceives the aromas, and perhaps feel hear the crunchy texture. There is sense stimulation before and during the consumption of food. Spence & Piqueras-Fiszman (2014) argue that "Flavour turns out to be one of the most multi-sensory of our everyday experiences"(Spence & Piqueras-Fiszman, 2014, p. 183). The sense of smell plays an important role when eating, just remember how food tastes when having a cold, not the best experience. Spence & Piqueras-Fiszman (2014) state that previous research has demonstrated how what humans typically perceive as flavor actually comes from the olfactory sense, which may account for as much as 80-90%. Eating is a complex, and sensuous act; we cannot experience taste without the interlaced involvement with the other senses (Le Breton, 2017).

Other Worlds of Senses That Make Sense

Throughout history and philosophy, the senses have occupied an important place in the intake of knowledge. Carolyn Kosmeyer (2002) explains how the "five senses" were put into two categories by Aristotle, sight and hearing belonging to the higher, objective ones, and smell, taste, and touch belonging to the lower category. The "higher senses" corresponded to that classification because they experience things outside of the body, observing and hearing the world. Whereas the "lower senses" are based on more subjective experiences of the person, perceiving them inside our body (Korsmeyer, 2002, p. 25). Plato saw the sense of taste as being a corrupted sense related to gluttony and the flesh (Korsmeyer, 2002, p. 17). Korsmeyer argues that besides this hierarchy of the senses placing "of mind over body; of reason over sense; of man over beast and culture over nature" it also lines up with gendered notions that support the idea of "masculine" traits over "feminine" ones (2002, p. 30). These gendered concepts appear in both Plato's and Aristotle's views of the senses, where the "higher" senses are connected to masculine intellect, and female senses are belittled as dangerous pleasures (Korsmeyer, 2002). Even though scientific studies related to the senses have changed, traditional classification of "higher" and "lower" senses kept appearing in different theories and academic work (Korsmeyer, 2002).

The world tends to be audiovisual, we are constantly saturated by images and sounds, reaffirming the notion of a world view, a world vision, above anything else. Classen affirms that, "The proliferation of visual imagery in modernity promotes the notion that the world is, above all, something to see. This is conveyed, for example, by the expression 'world view', which implies that cosmologies, or systems of belief, can be visually mapped by anyone with an adequate overview" (2005, p. 147). The hierarchy of the senses is very often assumed as natural, however in other cultures the sensory worlds are different.

In Venezuela, the Warao, according to Classen (drawing from Wilbert [1987]) learn very carefully to identify plants for herbal cures through their nose, in case of failing the consequences can be fatal (1999). Food consumption creates important cultural knowledge, such is the case of the tea ceremony in China and Japan, which is a careful wisdom ritual and hymn to existence (Classen, 1999; Le Breton, 2017). Another case is the *Tzotzil*[9] of Mexico , where according to the energy a food possesses is how they describe the food. Hot or cold, they employ this concepts to organize their ways of living into heated or frozen worlds (Classen, 1999). Le Breton described how the Aivilik navigate the frozen landscapes through hearing in order to see, they always find their way and include a vast vocabulary for both auditory and olfactory experiences (2017). According to his studies, the Saami people in Northern Europe also relay on auditory cosmology, through sung narrations about the relationship between humans and the world. Each culture has a cosmology with different sensory energies, and as Classen points out "the dominant sensory medium of symbolic orientation can vary widely from culture to culture and can only be understood within the context of a particular culture and not through generalized external sensory paradigms" (2005, p. 160). To try to understand the culture of the Tzotzil with western paradigms of the senses would then be ridiculous, as their sensory universes mean more than just being guided by one sense.

Instead of a linear vision of the world it could mean more of a "sensory kaleidoscope" (Classen, 2005, p. 161). Knowing about other worlds of senses can allow for a recognition of how other cultures can exist and can experience food. As an outsider to other cultures, I don't suppose to understand how these other worlds work, but in my own food culture I can learn how cooking as inquiry and *sazón* can exist as a way of sensory knowledge.

[9] Descendants of the Mayan, still inhabiting Mexico.

Other Ways of Sensory Knowledge

The previous mentioned western thinking of sensory worlds devalues the embodied ways of knowing like the *sazón*, that uses smell, touch, and taste (Abarca, 2006). Abarca proposes the sensory epistemology of the *sazón* as the linkage between all the senses, as the experience of making food is something that uses our body in connection to the mind and that makes our personal and collective lives meaningful. In her studies, she argues that taste, smell, and touch allow for body experiences where cognitive and intuitive knowledge develops, and thus she rejects western notions about the "lower senses" being the downfall of reason. Abarca's work examines how through the sense of sight for example, precise culinary measurements are established as the only acceptable culinary practice. Sight in cooking has become the main measuring sense, and it has absorbed all the other senses. Even though the *sazón* uses all the senses including sight, it is not necessarily the most powerful one in a hierarchical paradigm. Abarca proposes a horizontal order through the "cognitive sensory logic of the *sazón*"(2006, p. 59). In this order, the senses can feed each other and work together, not just individually.

We are accustomed to viewing the world just via our individual and separated senses, yet this is not always true. It wasn't until the 20th century that there was a change of paradigm in neuroscience, from the isolated senses and stigmatization of synesthesia into a more integrated multi-sensorial model (Howes, 2004). Scientific research has now confirmed this in the form of synesthesia, that also results into the experience of flavor (Sweeney, 2009). Synesthesia, a term that for neuroscientists means "an extremely rare condition in which the stimulation of one sensory modality is accompanied by a perception in one or more modalities" (Howes, 2004, p. 141). Synesthesia can be understood as a medical condition, however it can also be perceived as a term to describe the act of engaging with most or all of the senses at once, that results into other ways of sensing the world (Howes, 2004, 2006). David Sutton defines Synesthesia as "the way that sensory experiences cannot be compartmentalized, but seem, rather, to feed off each other" (Sutton, 2001, p. 305). From an anthropologic view, Synesthesia could then be understood as a union of the senses, where the experience of one sense leads a further sense. In recent years, there has been studies about how synesthesia is a key to food memories. For example, Sutton's work about the ways that Kalymnian islanders use 'synesthetic metaphors'[10] in Greece (2001), as well as other scholars who have explored synesthesia in different ethnographic works (Keane, 2003; Meneley, 2008; Young, 2005).

[10] A synesthetic metaphor can be for example, "listen to that smell".

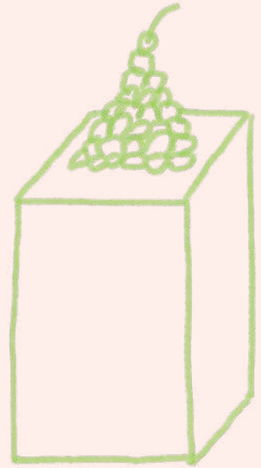
Another term related to the union of the senses is intersensoriality. Howes argues that, contrary to synesthesia, intersensoriality is not a synesthetic model in which the senses are intermingled. Intersensoriality is therefore a model where the threads of perception are intertwined. Sometimes the senses act in unison, while in other cases the sensations are contradictory or chaotic (Howes, 2006).

The *sazón* then similar to synesthesia, delves into the sensuous aspects of food from everyday life, transforming them into multi-sensory experiences with meaning, emotion, memory, and value, actively using all the senses to create embodied and active knowledge (Sutton, 2010). Howes points out how to perceive the world in an intersensorial way does not necessarily mean we must feel everything at the same time. He claims that, "To imagine the senses as knotted does not mean that sensations must be conceptualized as simultaneous. Just as in making a weaving the strands are woven together in sequence, so in perception does one sensation often follow another to form different patterns of experience" (Howes, 2004, p. 9). In this perception, the senses can then be understood as intersensorial, which is a multidirectional concept that cannot focus only on one sensory field, as the senses interactively work together (Howes, 2004). I find synesthesia and intersensoriality interesting for my research as they are other ways to understand the senses, to experience food, and to trigger memories.

Besides sensuous experiences when cooking, cooked meals can also be presented in certain aesthetic ways to create multi-sensory experiences, not only in restaurants but also at home. In Chinese cuisine, for example, meals are beautifully crafted to present a sensual feast of colors, aromas, and flavors. Their extensive use of different textures and tastes create a remarkable culinary experience. "The art of cooking is based on a subtle sensorial hierarchy: taste comes first, but sight and smell are necessary complements that enhance its effect. The presentation and aromatic preparation of a dish is not a second-order task" (Le Breton, 2017, p. 183). In the next chapter we will explore how food can also be beautiful, besides being a multi-sensorial experience.

Food as an Artistic Medium







This chapter delves into the intersection of food and art. It begins by posing the question of whether food can be beautiful, setting the stage for an in-depth examination of food as an artistic medium, not only a material. As food and art are associated with the culinary world, I will start by investigating how chefs relate to food and how food can also be a meaningful art practice within everyday cooking. Beyond the culinary realm, this chapter explores how food integrates into the art world. The different ways in which food can be approached within art are examined as well as examples of artist working with food in their practice. Finally, I carefully research different contemporary food artists/designers/chefs that have been working with food, that create a source of boundless creativity and lay a foundation for further critically engaging work.

Chapter 4

Is Food Beautiful?

Food can be described as beautiful; however, this wasn't always the case. In his essay in 2009, Kevin W. Sweeney asks if a soup can be beautiful. He exemplifies how the adjective beautiful has been regarded quite exclusive to the realm of the living by different philosophers. For example, Plato claimed that the term beautiful was reclusive to those objects that we can see and hear, thus a warm wholesome soup could not be beautiful (Sweeney, 2009). This argument is connected to the ideas presented in the previous chapter, about "higher" and "lower" senses. As proposed before, the senses can feed each other and work together, not just individually or hierarchically. Food is extremely sensorial, extending beyond its appeal. Food is meant to be ingested to fully experience it, and we use all the senses. Thus, a soup that can be smelled, slurped, and enjoyed, can be beautiful as it can entice a multisensorial experience.

In the first chapter, I explained how *mole* is a dish that forms part of Mexican National Cuisine. Visually *mole* is not very appealing as it is a brown and thick sauce. However, for me it's extremely beautiful because it has a cultural and emotional meaning. In this way, food can also be appreciated because it transcends its appeal. It might not be liked by someone outside of my Mexican food culture, but it still has meaning and history within its flavor. Besides this, it also has emotional meaning for me because it's a dish that my mom cooks with care and love, a dish that makes me feel closer to her.

Other researchers besides Sweeney argument in favor of food being beautiful. Matteo Ravasio employs an object centered model for aesthetic appreciation of nature in the realm of food, where he defines food landscape as "the set of food habits typical of a certain territory" (2018, p. 309). Ravasio proposes his own object-oriented model that includes intentionality, historicity, normativity, authenticity, appropriation, and meaning. This model is interesting because it aims to explore the aesthetic recognition of food that applies to the globalized era we live on, where the homogenization of food has driven the interest in more traditional and authentic food ingredients, processes, and dishes (Ravasio, 2018). In Mexico for example, the search for authentic nixtamalized *masa* can be quite exhaustive. Neighborhood *tortillerías*[11] are opting for *Maseca* in their fresh *masa*, because of its lower price. This bad quality maize flour is risking traditional native maize production in Mexico. Following Ravasio's model, maize needs to be appreciated as a meaningful and sacred food, whose biodiversity and knowledge are in danger. In this sense, autochthonous maize can also be beautiful because of its authenticity.

[11] A place where fresh tortillas and maize *masa* is made and sold.

Food can then be beautiful in different ways and entail a whole appreciation experience. Besides the sensory, cultural, historical, emotional, and authenticity dimensions within food, it can also be aesthetic in its artistic dimension. Lee argues that "Food is art when the taster or creator assumes the role as a percipient and assigns meaning to the food experience. And if the intensity of the experience is unifying, in such that it provokes thinking, qualitative immediacy, and momentous feeling, the food itself becomes an expressive object riddled with aestheticism"(2022b, p. 9). We give meaning to food when we eat it, but also when we prepare it. Food and cooking can be appreciated within its artistic dimension. Hence, food can be an exciting medium to work with, where different dimensions intertwine to create layers of meaning.

Food as a Medium, not Only a Material

In the second chapter titled The Materials of Life in Making: Anthropology, Archeology, Art and Architecture, Tim Ingold (2013) introduces an experiment he had been conducting in a course he taught. Ingold asked students to gather different objects and then to collect materials around the found objects. Some of the first objects gathered were "coins, paper clips, drinks cans", while the materials corresponded to "stuff like sand, gravel, mud and leaf litter" (2013, p. 17). The materials were carried in containers, and then smeared in a board. Contrary to objects, materials need to be contained. Ingold continues to describe the insights gained during the experiment and he writes the following reflection:

> I think what was most astonishing about them was the way in which they registered the traces of movement and flow: on the one hand the manual and bodily gestures of ourselves, as practitioners; on the other hand, the particular flow patterns of the mixtures we had made. I suppose, in retrospect, that we should not have been so astonished by this; after all, it corresponds to our most commonplace experience in the kitchen. Next time you are making soup, pay attention to the way your stirring gesture with the spoon both induces and responds to viscosities and currents of the mixed ingredients in the pan. What is odd is that studies of the material culture of kitchens have generally concentrated on pots and pans, and spoons, to the virtual exclusion of the soup. The focus, in short, has been on objects rather than materials. Yet on second thoughts, this is not a division between what we find in the kitchen: objects here; materials there. It is rather a difference of perspective. Householders might think of pots and

> pans as objects, at least until they start to cook, but for the dealer in scrap metal, they are lumps of material. (2013, pp. 18–19)

Ever since I read this paragraph years ago, it made me think of food differently. Ingold argues how studies around material culture often exclude the material contained in pots and pans. However, when cooking a soup or shaping a bread loaf, the materiality of these foods cannot be ignored. A soup is made of different ingredients; they are chopped and cooked, a liquid is poured, and spices are added. Just as metal is transformed to give shape to a pot, edible materials are transformed to make meals, in this case a soup. Food is very interesting in the sense that it is a malleable material that allows many different forms, and in the same way, as discussed previously, it can carry memories and powerful meaning. Food then becomes a medium, not only a material.

Talking about food as a medium involves discussing gastronomy. As suggested in the previous chapter, food can be beautiful, and chefs transmit emotions and meaning through their edible works of art. As Raviv points out, chefs have "contributed to a public perception of food as a creative medium by positioning food as works of art as well as merely dinner" (2010, p. 9). Lately in modern gastronomy, chefs resemble artists, "their culinary skills are paralleled to artisanal craftsmanship, their intelligence to artistic creativity, and their food creations to works of art" (Lee, 2022b, p. 1). In restaurants, chefs prepare, cook, and plate mesmerizing artworks to be eaten, often creating multi-sensory experiences. Unlike design, artistic creativity in the kitchen allows for experimentation and recreation that builds further knowledge and is combined with a desire to create certain flavors, textures, and liking.

Food as an artistic medium is also employed by chefs in spaces besides kitchens. For example, in 2007, the contemporary Catalan chef Ferran Adrià participated in documenta 12, an art event which takes place in Kassel, Germany and happens every 5 years. Adrià was the first and only chef to be invited to the art event, marking a turning point in the gastronomic, cultural, and artistic institutions (Perullo, 2017). Although Adrià doesn't think of himself as a chef, he creates works of art. His work has influenced research about food and art, as well as the way other chefs and artists use food (Raviv, 2010). The Catalan chef's work mixes scientific and culinary knowledge that can be seen as an artistic performance. Sipahi & Yılmaz highlight that, "his food presentation, which breaks prejudices, encourages reconsideration, focuses on discovering texture in addition to taste and smell makes it difficult for them to be considered as anything but artistic performances that use food as a medium" (2017, p. 333). Adrià's groundbreaking work, exhibited at documenta 12, became a milestone in the field of food as an artistic medium, paving the way for other works of art.



Figure 11
A dish from Noma
Note. From *Dish of greens. Some of the vegetables are grilled. Some are fresh. And others have been lightly salted. The plate beneath has been brushed with a paste made of dry scallops* [Photograph], City Foodsters, 2015, Flickr (https://www.flickr.com/photos/cityfoodsters/19259696676/in/photostream/). CC BY 2.0

Other chefs after Adrià, such as Danish chef René Redzepi explore alternative gastronomic possibilities through flavors and changing taste norms. Redzepi focuses on local ingredients, tradition, contemporary methods, and experiences (Bröcker, 2017; Perullo, 2018). In his work, Redzepi creates edible landscapes that engage the diner into a multi-sensory experience of contemplation and reflection, by recontextualizing food and transforming the old into new, giving the diners a fresh perspective on it. Having a dinner in his restaurant Noma (Figure 11), is going on a journey through different small ecosystems, from the sea shore to the forest (Davis, 2012). Redzepi launched in 2022 Noma projects, "a new organization that aims to channel the restaurant's collective knowledge, craft, and spirit into a leading food innovation company", as stated in their website (About Us, n.d.). In overall, his work innovates by merging tradition and local knowledge with contemporary approaches to cuisine.

In the art world, food also acts as a medium. Fabiana Senkpiel lists the use of food as an art medium in three different modes. The first mode is when the artwork is edible and in most cases the audience is invited to eat it. Food becomes an edible art material where "the property (edibility) and functionality (food carrier) of the material used are retained despite the change of context from everyday life to the art world" (Senkpiel, 2021, p. 93). When ingesting the artwork, the act of eating can also become part of the artwork. On the second mode, food is used as a medium that cannot be touched by the audience. The context of this mode is usually a gallery space or an institution, and here, the cultural meaning of food is important. The third mode Senkpiel suggests is material agency, where "the immediate edibility of food gradually disappears in the works of art in which it is used" (2021, p. 97). In this last mode, food then perishes or transforms with the artwork across time.

Food can act as a medium in the intersection of cuisine and art. Chef and researcher Felix Bröcker is a doctoral student investigating this topic. He uses conceptual artist Rirkrit Tiravanija's food related artwork to examine its meaning. Tiravanija is an international contemporary artist, who employs food as a medium loaded with cultural symbolism and meaning. His work highlights the complexity of his identity. Tiravanija has Thai heritage, however, he was born in Argentina, and is currently living between different places. In his work Untitled 1990 (Pad Thai) (Figure 12 & 13), he deals with questions of identity by cooking by serving a foreign dish in a New York gallery (Bröcker, 2017). The history of the Pad Thai dish is as complex as Tiravanija's own identity. However, Tiravanija utilizes food as a means to an end; in some of his pieces, taste and culinary excellence are irrelevant (Bröcker, 2021).



Figure 12

Guests interact with Tiravanija's artwork.
Note. From *Untitled (pad thai) at Paula Allen Gallery* [Photograph], David Zwirner Hong Kong gallery, 1990 (https://www.tatlerasia.com/lifestyle/arts/how-is-rirkrit-tiravanija-pad-thai-art)



Figure 13

Tiravanija Cooking Pad Thai
Note. From *Do we Dream Under the Same Sky* [Photograph], Art Basel, 2015 (https://www.schirn.de/en/magazine/whats_cooking/vom_atelier_an_den_esstisch_rirkrit_tiravanija/)

Both artists and chefs are using food as medium, that involves using food as something more than merely a material. Bröcker compares Adria's and Tiravanija's artworks to suggest that in their practice, they both use "artisanal activity, conceptual thinking and aesthetic medium"(2017, p. 186). Chefs after Adrià, such as Redzepi, keep expanding beyond the culinary realms to include art-historical approaches combined with the aesthetic (Bröcker, 2017). Both Tiravanija's and Adrià's work became a turning point as it influenced contemporary artists and chefs, opening a door to employing food as an artistic medium in different and new contexts besides the kitchen or the restaurant.

Cooking as an Everyday Artistic Practice

In the previous chapter I demonstrated how chefs use food as an artistic medium, however, cooking in other contexts can also be considered an artistic practice. Nicola Perullo (2017) suggests a new perspective that already accept cuisine as an art of the everyday filled with aesthetic value. Perullo delves into how cuisine can be art, existing in a range that includes the old familiarity with new innovations, or ordinary everyday life at home with exceptional experiences at the restaurant (2017). Lee highlights how previous researchers have focused on culinary research through an elitist lens, which leads to the reinforced idea that neglects the experiences of the everyday, promoting a dualistic elitist/non-elitist view of cooking that ignores how "art and aesthetics are not privileged products accessible only to a selected few, but something foregrounded in all human experiences"(2022b, p. 2). Talking about culinary aesthetics should include all culinary situations and experiences. These intake on culinary aesthetics then fits with shared meals as an aesthetic practice, where an experience such as sharing food across a common table with other individuals is "a powerful symbol of human togetherness" (Bröcker, 2017, p. 176). Cooking and sharing food at home can then also be a highly aesthetic experience.

From the Plate to the Exhibition, Food Expressed in Different Gradations

In different ways food is an art medium, and therefore cooking can also be art, but then how is food materialized into art? Cooking as an artistic practice can end up in a dish or in a table, just like the work of chefs Ferran Adrià's or Rene Redzepi's. In their practice, visual perception makes an important part, where form and plating are important to express their idea as well as for the observer to reflect on it. However, food doesn't necessarily need to be presented on a plate, there are many other ways to do it.

Plating is essential for cuisine. It adds up to the multi-sensorial experience of food, which is arranged to look beautiful and appetizing. To approach aesthetic plating, Spence (2016) compares painting and plating, which have broad differences regarding color preferences, the frame or medium, and how they are presented. Spence then suggests a series of points regarding plating, starting with balance. A harmonious way is more visually attractive than food that is not. Balance affects our liking, as well the shape of the plate. The

second point includes the oblique effect as people tend to prefer horizontal and vertical lines. Other points include plating by following the golden ratio and the idea of odd numbers versus even. However, these studies are western focused, and there are no conclusive studies that prove that this makes food more appealing. Plating, like art is subjective,

Food is then repetitively compared to art. When plating, cooks and chefs often get inspired by other forms of art. In occasions, chefs try to turn the edible creations into visually pleasing works of art, to then influence the preferences and stimulate the brain of the person observing the plated creation (Spence, 2016). In other contexts, plating can be made in a broader canvas; the plate doesn't have to be a plate, and food can be presented into an entire room. Recently there has been modern innovative ideas as well as bizarre supports for food. Spence and Piqueras-Fiszman argue how chefs have lately opted for more innovative and authentic ideas to tell a story when presenting food, "...bricks, black slate, disks of charred rough-hewn wood, hay, banana leaves and packaging" (2014, p. 133). While some chefs stick to artistic plating with different shapes and textures in elegant porcelain plates, it is also interesting how others are resourcing to other ways of presenting food foraged materials– lined up on the floor, arranged into large, monumental towers, due to reasons that range from necessity, sustainability, or terroir. I see these ideas as an exciting way to present food, if it results into a functional and comfortable experience. As chefs and artists become more interested in creating multi-sensory experiences, they are turning to extraordinary materials, objects, and designs to present food, creating memorable narratives and experiences for diners.

In the art world, performances related to food and cooking have now become very common (Borghini & Baldini, 2022, p. 310). Cooking as an artistic practice can be expressed in the private space like home kitchens, in the public space like restaurants or public areas, or in museums (Borghini & Baldini, 2022). For example, in 2019 artist Eva Aguila presented a project titled Comida a Mano in "Current: LA" biennale. For this project, a *comal*[12] she had commissioned was placed in a park and Maria Ornelas, a local café owner, made fresh maize tortillas using her own embodied memories (Russeth, 2021). Aguila's aim was to erase the stigma associated with eating with your hands, in this case eating a tortilla filled with guacamole, *nopales* , *frijoles negros*, and more. Aguilar's edible performance was a way to connect with her Mexican heritage, where food and cooking played an important aspect (Figure 14 & 15).

[12] A clay disc used for cooking maize tortillas or other foods.

†Figure 14

A tortilla with nopales

Note. From *Eva Aguila's project Comida a Mano at the Reseda Recreation Center, part of the 2019 "Current:LA" biennial.* [Photograph], Panic studio LA, Courtesy City of Los Angeles Department of Cultural Affairs (DCA) (https://www.artnews.com/art-news/artists/art-food-collaborations-vaginal-davis-rirkrit-tiravani-ja-1234603683/)





†Figure 15

Maria Ornelas making tortillas

Note. From *Chef Maria Ornelas at work.* [Photograph], Panic studio LA, Courtesy City of Los Angeles Department of Cultural Affairs (DCA) (https://www.artnews.com/art-news/artists/art-food-collaborations-vaginal-davis-rirkrit-tiravanija-1234603683/)

As mentioned before, food can be exhibited but not necessarily eaten (Senkpiel, 2021). Barbara Kirschenblatt-Gimblett claims that:

> The showpieces in culinary Olympics and exhibitions of pastry and confectionery are exhibited, but they are not generally eaten (with the exception of hot entries). Eat them at their freshest and there would be nothing to exhibit. Wait till after the exhibition and they are not worth eating. They are literally a feast for the eye and they are called showpieces. (1999, p. 3).

Freshness is a huge issue with exhibiting food, because of the inevitable aspect of time, food needs to be eaten on the same day, if not immediately. Photography helps to document food before it vanishes. The artworks are ingested and the body assumes the form of an "epistemic organ" (Senkpiel, 2021, p. 92).

The banquet is another way in which food is materialized into art. “Starting with breast-feeding and continuing with daily meals, banquets or religious rituals, the forms and reasons why people eat together go from an embodied commensality to an enculturated one” (Arzak, 2016, p. 232). Banquets are a representation of other ways to exhibit food besides the plate. Yes, plates are included but, in a banquet, it is more relevant how food elements and meals are arranged in a table. The term banquet comes from the renaissance, it became a festive event, extravaganza being a synonym for it (Stourna, 2018). The idea of the banquet in the form of food installations is still being used, quite differently and sometimes in a more corporate and exclusive context. Stourna argues that:

> “the table becomes a new type of stage, where food and drink are displayed before being consumed, and a space that unites all the spectators/banqueters surrounding it, almost like a small-scale gastronomic theatre in-the-round. At the same time, food design is particularly emphasised, since recipes may be conceived especially for the event” (Stourna, 2018, p. 20)

The work of some contemporary artists such as Laila Gohar still employ the idea of the banquet, while Gohar's work cannot be simplified to it, the way she uses food as a medium to create specific menus, meals, and ornamentation, using a stage in the form of tables or sculptural objects reminds of it.



Figure 16

Carême's artworks

Note. From *A range of Dubois desserts from Cuisine Classique emphasising display and consumption* [Photograph], (n.d.), (https://www.architectural-review.com/essays/let-them-eat-cake-urbain-dubois)

Food in art has a long history through different art movements, performances, and artworks. However, for the interest of this research I will start by using the work of chef Antonin Carême as a starting point and then focus on examining contemporary examples of food as an artistic and edible medium. Carême was known as one of the first modern chefs, he combined both traditional and contemporary cooking methods in a fundamentally sound structure that allowed all the components–recipes and various notes appended to each section–to make sense in relation to one another (Parkhurst Ferguson, 2003) (Figure 16). He took an architectural approach in his work, where he built different picturesque objects that combined sugar, pastries, and sometimes inedible materials (Condello, 2009). On most occasions, his work was meant to be admired instead of eaten. Carême’s work is fascinating as his practice was situated on the intersection between architecture and cuisine, creating edible environments that later on inspired new artists and chefs.

In recent years, a contemporary creator, Laila Gohar, has made up a career from working with food as a medium. Photos of Gohar's work includes monumental towers of langoustine (Figure 17), large scale desserts with thousands of strawberries (Figure 18) or intricate delicate small landscapes with pastel tones (Figure 19). Laila was born in Egypt and has lived and worked in the US for the last couple of years. She doesn't describe herself as a chef nor an artist. In an interview for Purple magazine, when asked to define what she does now, she replied the following:

> "The other day, someone said I made art out of the everyday. I don't know if I really believe that, but I thought that was a nice thing to say. I was born with this need to express. That's why, for me, food is just the excuse. It happens to be a very immediate medium to transmit emotion from one person to another. Food requires all your senses, whereas most media require less. I find that kind of transfer to be really interesting. " (Crespo, n.d.).



Figure 17
Shrimp and langoustine tower in Galeries Lafayette opening event
Note. From *Shrimp and langoustine tower* [Photograph], by Villa Eugenie, 2019, (https://lailagohar.com/langoustine-tower/)



Figure 18
Dessert with thousands of strawberries for HAY
Note. From *Hay Sobremesa Launch* [Photograph], by Laila Gohar (n.d.). (https://lailagohar.com/hay-sobremesa-launch/)



Figure 19
Food arranged on different objects over a table
Note. From *UFO table* [Photograph], by Laila Gohar (n.d.). (https://lailagohar.com/ufo-table/)

Gohar thinks of food as a way to communicate emotions, her work blends food with design as she sometimes collaborates in creating functional objects to showcase food, or to contain food. In another podcast interview she stated, "Food is a tool to bring people together" (Calderone, n.d.). Laila has designed tables, tableware, and objects that accompany the food she cooks and displays. Her work is meant to be eaten and enjoyed in company of others.

However, her work mostly focuses on food assemblages for luxury clients, including galleries, museums, openings and events like the Salone in Milan. Quite often her edible art is not open to the public, only to certain social circles. Gohar has worked for different luxury brands such as Prada, Hermès, Comme des Garçons, Simone Rocha (Figure 18), and Sotheby's. She has succeeded in creating monumental edible sculptures, in part thanks to the financing multinational brands can provide. While her work is astonishing and authentic, I also see how it reflects a society of excess. In a world of abundance, do we really need more langoustine mountains or using vegetables as candle holders? However, her work amazes, as she often builds architectural arrangements or surreal installations which don't always look edible to the eye.

Other artists also using food as a medium in a multi-sensory and experimental way are Ananas Ananas, formed by Elena Petrossian and Verónica González (Figure 20). Ananas Ananas is based in Los Angeles and Baja California. As they both have different cultural backgrounds, this blend and their identity shows in the work they do, by bringing Mexican or middle eastern flavors and ingredients. Their work is not just about creating sensorial experiences, as they also are critical about food production systems. In their exhibition Extraños (Figure 21) which was made in collaboration with Group Exhibit x Regina Hoyos, En La Superficie and Tierra Piedra, they highlight the ethical understandings around food and reflections around natural resources and food waste. They did so by depicting in gelatin like objects the water use to produce certain common foods, such as the potato. Their approach to food works beautifully as most of their work not only focuses on flavor and presentation, but also in the way the audience interacts with it. The foodscapes from Ananas Ananas attend not only to the cultural dimensions of food but also to the political and ecological implications in food materiality (Johnston & Goodman, 2015).



Figure 20
Fruit and vegetables hanged in fishing wire
Note. From *"Frutas y Verduras"* for Ananas Ananas Launch Party [Photograph], by K. Burton, 2019, (https://metalmagazine.eu/en/post/interview/anan-as-ananas)



Figure 21
Food waste soaked in gelatin forms and recycled water demonstrate the quantity of water required to manufacture an orange
Note. From *Extraños* [Photograph], by P. Molina, 2020, (https://metalmagazine.eu/en/post/interview/ananas-ananas)



Figure 22
Food plating
Note. From *Tropical Anthology* [Photograph], Abu Dhabi Art, 2022, (https://caiquetizzi.com/)



Figure 23
Food sculpture made with pineapples
Note. From *Tropical Anthology* [Photograph], Abu Dhabi Art, 2022, (https://caiquetizzi.com/)

Caique Tizzi, born in Sao Paulo and living and working in Berlin is another artist, cook and event organizer practicing an artistic approach to food. His events tend to be full of performance or rituals around the table, enhancing the act of eating together (Tizzi, 2019). In his work titled Tropical Anthology (Figure 22 & 23), he took a critical approach to work around tropical fruits, indigenous to the Americas and that were transformed into representational objects of colonization and conquest. He used food to create a sensual experience about a complex geopolitical situation. Tropical Anthology is a singing dinner about eating and appreciating food, where Caiqui designed a menu inspired by the Americas where dishes such as Cassava Cheese Balls and Cocoa and chocolate in shapes, textures, and temperatures form part of it (Tropical Anthology, a Singing Dinner by Caique Tizzi, 2022). Similar to Gohar, or Ananas Ananas, Tizzi's work is influenced by his identity as a Brazilian artist working in other contexts to produce performances about sharing and reflecting on food.

The artists exemplified before, form part of a large group of people interested and practicing the use of food as an edible and artistic medium. The appreciation of food as we know now didn't always receive this kind of exciting attention it gets now, as well as food studies wasn't an important subject in anthropological studies until recently (Marak, 2014). Food artists are looking to share such experiences that come from intimate memories from home in the form of old recipes or home cooked meals in a contemporary way of presenting.

Artistic Research

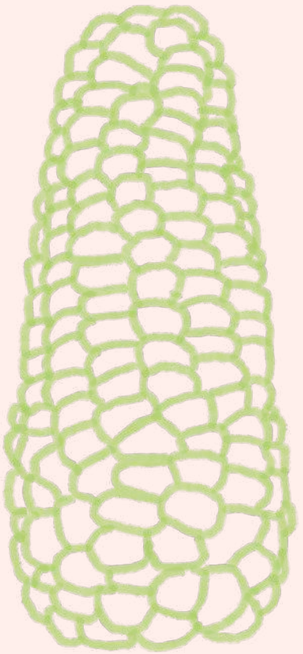
How can I materialize my own memories from home into edible artworks? As discussed in chapter 2, food memories are most likely to be formed in childhood from observation, or repetition (Almerico, 2014; Thrussell, 2016). This could be translated to watching other people cook in the kitchen, in my case, my mom or my grandmother. Le Breton argues that "A child enters into a gustatory system through a culinary system that is unique to a family immersed within particular social traditions. The mother's cooking remains the cuisine of reference and reverence throughout a person's life" (2017, p. 192) When I remember ingredients or recipes from a younger age, and I recreate them, I materialize memories from home into food. I recall things that happened in the past, even if those memories are sometimes projections or desirable projections of the past tainted by unpleasant memories (Janowski, 2012). Starting from my own food culture and memories, mixing in a background on how food is sensorial, meaningful, and an artistic medium, the following body of work is created.



Introducing the Ingredients

In the theoretical framework I have linked food with dimensions of identity, memories, the senses, and art by drawing inspiration from past experiences, such as observing my mom cook, listening to my grandmothers' stories, remembering flavors from home, or moving to another country. In the artistic research, individual ingredients as well as iconic food that have a cultural, historical, and personal baggage are selected and linked to my artistic practice as a contemporary designer. In the following pages I will share stories about maize, chili, and cakes. I will then explain why they are relevant to me and explore how they can used as an artistic medium. I chose the first two ingredients because they are essential to my food culture as a Mexican— waking up and having a meal made of maize and chilis is of my day-to-day. Cakes are also essential to my food culture; even though they are not originated from Mexico, they are a must in any celebration or fiesta. Cakes are interesting as they constitute a celebratory, sweet meal that unlike maize or chili, are eaten almost all around the world in a similar shape or different variations. The process of investigating each of these ingredients and food happened by remembering, cooking, eating, sharing stories, and keeping a food diary. Each ingredient and food will start by a contextualization that will include anecdotes from home, and then unfold into an artwork. Each artwork will turn into a process of self-reflection from different types of documentation (see Appendix A for documentation). Because edible artworks are temporary, detailed photographing, sketching, and food diary writing are essential.

Maize





Maize means everything to me, as it is the base of my food diet. My favorite dishes cannot exist without this grain that I used to eat daily in my home country. This particular ingredient has this potential because it has distinctive significance and/or special resonance due to cultural, societal, religious, and/or cosmological factors (Janowski, 2012). As seen in chapter one, this sacred cereal was the base of Mesoamerican civilizations and is still of great importance in Mexican food diets.

Masa

The maize grain is transformed into a dough, and then into different shapes, one of them the tortilla. The dough is called *masa* in spanish. The maize grain becomes *masa* through a process of nixtamalization, which consists of soaking the grains for a few hours and adding an alkaline product that could be for example limestone, shell powder or ashes (Metheny & Beaudry, 2015). The creation of maize dough allows for different culinary dishes: *tortillas, tamales, zacahuil, sopes, huaraches, tostadas, chilaquiles*, just to name a few of my favorites (Figure 24).

Maize tortillas are very special as they are vital for many dishes, the most popular being the taco. Lucky for me, shortly after moving to Finland and thanks to the Mexican friends I met in University I found out about a *tortillería* near my home. I occasionally make orders; the price is almost ten times more expensive than back at home, but sometimes I cave in to spoiling myself with the best tortillas one can find in this country. I had to get used to lowering my daily tortilla consumption, trading the flat round tortilla for European bread. The memory of going to the neighborhood tortillería with my mom comes to mind. We are driving home after school, I'm still on 5th grade of elementary school. A delicious home cooked meal is waiting for us at home, but we are missing something... tortillas.

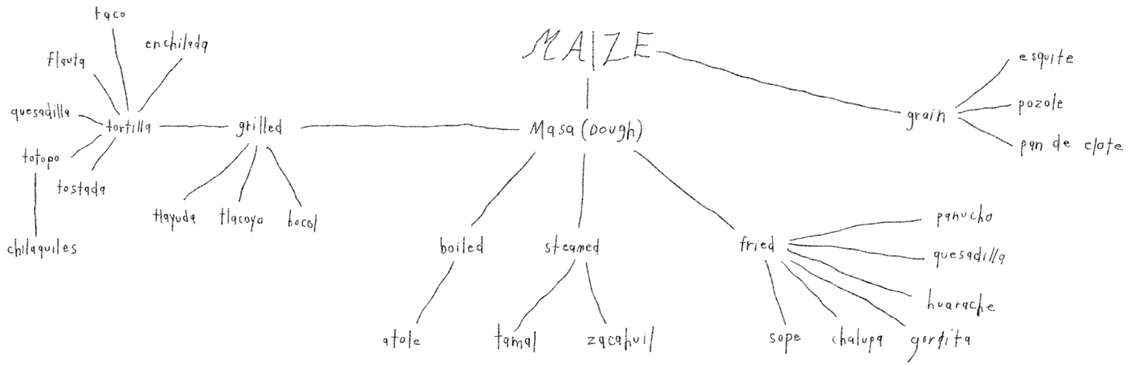


Figure 24
Different food made of maize, part of my individual food culture. The diversity of maize dishes extends beyond this map.

We finished the last kilo of them, so my mom needs to stop by the local *tortillería* (Figure 25). I wait in the vehicle while she orders. She passes me the bag with *tortillas* and *masa*, I place them on my lap, and it feels very warm, freshly made. I can't wait to get home and eat one warm tortilla. We are only a few blocks away from home, but I cannot resist. I slide my sneaky little kid fingers into the tortilla bag. My mom is driving and I'm on the back seat, she cannot look back, but she knows me. She shouts at me "¡*No comas tortillas que se te va a quitar el hambre!*" (Don't eat tortillas, your appetite will go away!), but I don't care. The tasty fresh *masa* of the tortilla feels like a warm in the mouth and very soft.



Figure 25
My local tortilleria back in my hometown.

I could keep going but decide to be a bit more patient. We arrive at home and before thinking of anything else I grab the tortilla bag and go straight to the kitchen. I get another tortilla, put a pinch of salt and squeeze a slice of lime on it. I love acidic flavors. It tastes incredibly good; the acidity and saltiness are balanced. One of the most incredible humble pleasures I can think of. The tortilla is fresh and soft, it tastes like genuine maize; with no preservatives at all.

Desayuno: A *Tostada* Landscape

Desayuno translates to breakfast, a very important meal in Mexico. A whole feast in front of you that can include seasonal fruit, coffee, fresh juice, the main salty dish containing meat or eggs, and *pan dulce* if you still have space. Back at home, it's a sin to leave my house without having breakfast. Sometimes I feel like I plan my entire days according to food. Thinking about food makes me happy because it reminds me of my family. Most of my nights I go to bed thinking what I will eat tomorrow morning, it excites me to wake up and cook something good and wholesome to start the day. El *desayuno* is my favorite meal of the day. Because of this, I thought why not start with a breakfast for the first art-work.

A Mexican breakfast can be many things. For this artwork I decided to go with *tostadas*. A food that can be contained within itself and it doesn't need any dish or cutlery. *Tostadas* can be a dish that has a toasted tortilla as a base, the toppings can vary, from beans and chicken to avocado and raw fish. I love to eat them because they are crunchy and can handle many ingredients on top. I normally stop at the third *tostada* but could really keep going. Tortillas, and *tostadas* are my 'daily bread'.

As stated before, Mexican food can be a multi-sensorial experience. When I eat *tostadas*, I use my hands in a very special way. They carefully hold the food, they add food that might fall from the *tostada*, and they feel the hard surface together with the warm ingredients.



Figure 26
My mother's garden back at home.



Figure 27
My mother's garden back at home.

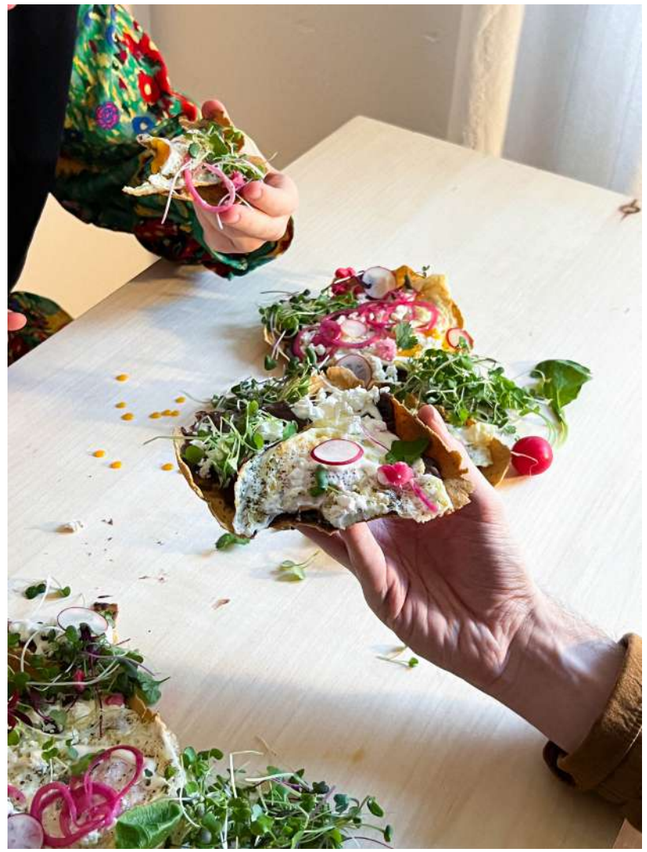
When I bite it, I hear the crunch; if it's not crunchy then it's not good. For me, eating this is a totally sensory act where sometimes I forget about anything else and focus on enjoying the food. It is a food that I devour delicately but also quick enough, so the *tostada* doesn't lose its crunchiness with the warm ingredients on top. When I think about my practice, *tostadas* fits perfectly as it allows me to experiment with different shapes and arrange-ments, and it also requires patience and carefulness. Before this installation, I tried making my own oven baked *tostadas*. This resulted in different organic shapes that could carry ingredients because of its natural shape when baked that curls up.

I started with some sketches, trying to picture how the *tostadas* would look like. After-wards I thought of the landscape, drawing up inspiration from my mom's garden back at home (Figure 26 & 27). It always had some green, pink, and white shades, even in the winter. I then planned which ingredients could work according to taste and colors. I wanted to use *frijoles negros* and fried eggs to eat it in the morning. I then thought of using pinks, greens, and whites. A good breakfast *tostada* always has *queso fresco* and *crema fresca*. It is quite hard to find substitutes for these two last ingredients as the ones from Mexico are very different. Personally, I like using feta cheese as it crumbles and has a fresh, sour taste as a replacement for *queso fresco* and crème fraîche as a substitute for *crema fres-ca*. For the pink shades I used small radishes and some pickled onions I made with haba-nero, orange, and oregano. While building up the artwork the process was very intuitive, it was like painting on a canvas. I had my ingredients on one side, and the wooden table where I was creating the landscape.

The combination of flavors was tasty. The *tostadas* were crunchy enough, while the *frijoles negros* and eggs give strong and bold flavors, the greens, radish and pickles give it a fresh taste (Figure 28 & 29). From far away it looked like a little garden with different details and shapes. I invited three of my closest friends and they grabbed a *tostada* and ate it, savoring each bite and asking what they were eating as most of the ingredients and flavors were alien to them. No cutlery was used, as it should be while eating *tostadas* (Figure 30). The *tostada* landscape worked as a medium for remembering ingredients and dishes from home. As I explained each layer of ingredients, stories related to them reappeared. I explained how I used to eat this dish very often back at home, how my mother would prepare it, and what similar dishes exist.



☥Figure 28
Maize, frijoles negros, fried eggs, feta cheese, crème fraîche, pickled onions, radishes, greens, and Acuyo.



☥Figure 30
Tostadas are meant to be eaten without cutlery.



☥Figure 29
A tostada landscape with different shades.

Cakes



As mentioned before, cakes are relevant because they are part of my food culture and joyful moments of celebration within my family. It goes beyond eating the cake, as my grandmother's experience in cakemaking is the first reason of why I got interested in working with food. Remembering, and remaking her cakes are a way of keeping her memories alive. In this act of remembrance, I also find myself standing against the tide of industrialized cakes that dominate the modern food industry, where homemade food is not valuable enough. My refusal to use pre-packaged sweets or readymade cake flours, recognize the worth of handmade food, and embodies a strong feeling of resistance.

When researching about Mexican cakes, I couldn't find relevant historical information. From my personal experiences, I know that cakes are an important celebratory food in Mexico. As a child, I remember going every birthday to a party store to choose my candle for the cake. It wasn't just any candle, but a sculpture of a specific animated character for children. Besides the candle, there is a specific singing moment around the birthday cake. For me, cakes symbolize a ritual on every birthday, I can't imagine celebrating something important without a piece of cake. This act of celebrating appears in *quinceañeras*[13] , weddings, religious celebrations, and historical days. Every celebration is filled with flavorful feasts, loud music, colors, dancing, and joy. Mexicans love to celebrate; it is a custom and the cake is a must.

[13] A big celebration for girls when they turn 15 years old, originating from pre-Columbian cultures.

Where it All Started

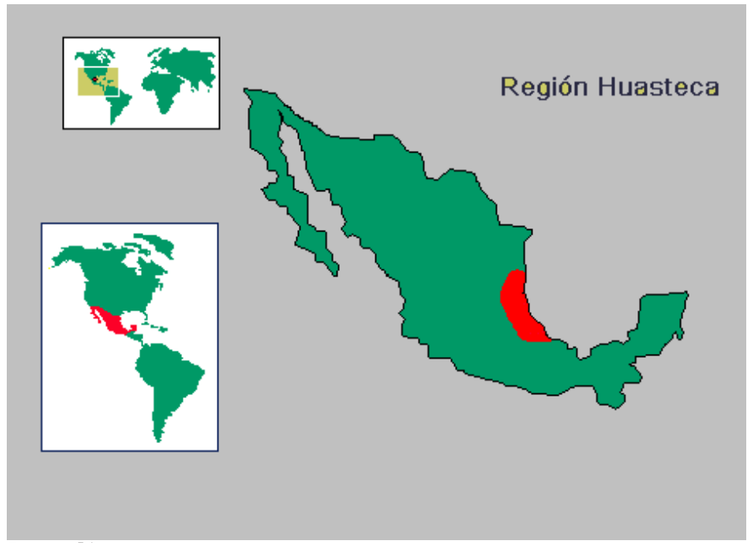


Figure 31
Map of La Huasteca
Note. From *Región Huasteca en México* [Illustration], Limbo, 2006, Wikipedia (https://es.wikipedia.org/wiki/Regi%C3%B3n_Huasteca#/media/Archivo:Regi%C3%B3n_Huasteca.png) CC BY 3.0

Like most of our culture, my family's culinary heritage dates to the beginning of the last century, with my great-great grandmother working as a cook on a very large rural hacienda type property located near two large rivers and the sea in a region of Mexico known as *la Huasteca*[14] (Figure 31) . This region coveys a rich culinary tradition stemming from the unique inputs of the area, where my great-grandmother used her imagination to prepare unique dishes with her old pre-Columbian tools, such as the *molcajete*[15] . Later, she moved to the city where she became a single mother working hard all her life to support not only her daughter but also her granddaughter, my *abuelita* Amparo (Figure 32). Years later, the adolescent Amparo graduated as an executive secretary in a modest but competent school where she paid for her studies by cleaning the classrooms. This schooling allowed her to get a job at an early age (16 years old) in a famous commercial establishment owned by Spaniards, where she began to nourish herself with delicious Spanish recipes because of her companions of Spanish origin. This connection originated in the family a culinary syncretism, from *la Huasteca* and Spanish culture.

[14] La Huasteca is a geographical area with a strong cultural identity that lies partially along the Gulf of Mexico.
[15] A utensil of pre-Columbian origin, like a mortar, generally made of basalt.

When she got married and stopped working to take care of her home and six children, she educated herself by reading recipes in famous magazines of that time as well as inheriting recipes from her grandmother who lived with the young couple and so they cooked together. After her grandmother passed away, Amparo continued to educate herself by taking classes in different cooking schools, including one in a governmental institution that helped families, and she also took handicraft classes. With all that knowledge and experience, she dedicated herself to making wedding and quinceañera cakes for a couple of years for which she was in high demand. Unfortunately, she did not have the support of her husband, who corresponded to the macho stereotype of that time, because he disliked having to transport the cakes in his vehicle and that people thought he was not capable enough to support his family on his own. So, from then on, she only made modest but delicious cakes that people could pick up on foot at her house.

Throughout her life, my *abuelita* Amparo continued to elaborate and learn rich recipes. My mother still remembers my grandmother's rich gastronomy and how it accompanied all her celebrations and turned them into a feast of kings, in spite of her father's modest income as a laborer. At Christmas time, for example, she would make a pine tree of cookies whose meticulous preparation required precision and care so that the cookies would not break when assembled one on top of the other. Of course, the broken pieces were taken care of with particular relish among her children.



Figure 32
My abuelita Amparo in my hometown Tampico

Since a young age, I remember my *abuelita* Amparo preparing desserts for all special occasions. For example, once in Christmas she made a lovely cookie house which she later raffled amongst all her grandchildren. She taught me how to make several cookies, which I curiously observed and wrote down the ingredients. Her creativity didn't stop in the kitchen as she also taught me how to make piñatas and how to use the sewing machine.

At the present time there can't be any family birthday party without my grandmother's traditional *pastel de chocolate* (chocolate cake), no Sunday gathering without at least one pie, or baking an enormous diversity of cookies around Christmas even though it's 30 degrees outside in my hometown. Every time my aunt Julia makes a pie using her recipe or my mother cooks a dish she learned from my *abuelita*, or I make her delicious and rich *pastel* recipe, her memories and history comes alive. It is through food that I connect to my past, this intangible knowledge that exists within the kitchen and is passed from generations to generations.

Queremos pastel: A Sensuous Act of Remembring



Figure 33
Green landscape made of vanilla and matcha with raspberries
Photo by Radul Radulović

To materialize these previous childhood and family memories, I organized the exhibition *Queremos Pastel*[16]*:* A Sensuous Act of Remembering; a multi-sensorial exhibition, interweaving food as an artistic medium in the form of soft and sweet edible sculptures paired with a peaceful live soundscape performed by artist Latvusto. Along with vanilla, and chocolate, this carefully crafted edible installation that included different flavors, colors, and smells aimed to transport the audience to my own inner world of senses, intimate memories, and nostalgia for soft and sweet edible sculptures. In April 2023, the exhibition took place in Asbestos Art Space on a Sunday evening where friends as well as strangers met in a small space to enjoy the experience (Figure 33).

For the execution of the exhibition, I decided to make four big cakes and small little cupcakes, where each cake had their own concept and unique flavors. During the previous week, I experimented with flavors, using my grandmother's cake recipes of vanilla and chocolate as a base, and building up more flavors from adding ingredients such as homemade Finnish berries jam, passion fruit curd, different buttercreams, and mascarpone frostings. The exhibition required a lot of preparation beforehand, so that on Sunday the work was simplified to assembling, sculpting, and crafting the artworks (Figure 34).

[16] *Queremos pastel* translates to we want cake, a popular Mexican phrase.



Figure 34
Me decorating the landscape with fennel, sage, and rosemary.
Photo by Radul Radulović

To exhibit the edible art, I decided to use natural stone surfaces as the raw material and colors gave a natural background for the sculptures . I also made individual cards to explain the flavors and possible allergies. The exhibition opened at 16, which gave time to enjoy the soundscape and appreciate the edible sculptures. The eating performance began at 17, where I cut all the cakes and passed slices along all the visitors (Figure 35). During the whole evening I became a host, sharing and serving cake.

This exhibition was different from the previous installations as it was in a public gallery space. The artworks were displayed in white pedestals, which gave a higher artistic value to the artworks. By being on the pedestals the audience approached them carefully, admiring its shapes and forms. “even though I don’t like cakes, I tried four different ones. I was curious to try the artwork and feel it”, a guest noticed. This desire to try the cake even though they were not fond of it could mean that they approached the cake as an artwork, leaving aside any predisposition of taste. During the whole evening no one dared to cut the cake by themselves, they would always approach me and ask if they could get another slice.

The edible artworks were the center of the event, and main topic of discussion. “the cakes look so condensed; it feels like slicing actual sculptures”, a friend told me. In this case, the cakes served as a surprise food. The cakes are fanciful, each one has a different personality, and my intention is that they attract attention, that they generate surprise. Nowadays, there has been a cake boom for making hyper realistic cakes; cakes that appear to be something else. This trend has been all over social media in the form of videos and memes and can be hypnotizing to watch. While I do search for an element of surprise and fascination when making cakes, I believe my artistic style comes from a homemade feeling that celebrates imperfection, soft colors, experimental shapes, and landscape inspired ornamentation, where everything is edible, and taste is as important as the visual aspect of the artworks.



Figure 35
Cutting the sculptures and passing around slices.
Photo by Radul Radulović

In the exhibition, being surrounded by such a nice community made the experience very special (Figure 36). Food served as an artistic medium to bring strangers into a space that made them feel comfortable, and at the same time the flavors recalled some of their own personal childhood memories around sweets.

A guest in the exhibition published an instagram post describing the whole exhibition. The following is an extract from that post:

> "The multisensorial, flavor and colorful, good smelling event was full of people creating a little embodied, immersive and changing natural performance, a resemblance of a good children's birthday party or any happy gathering with friends and family. Intimate memories were turned to something universal, and sense of belonging, family and home was momentarily present and transported to random group of people, strangers and visitors from all around the world in *Queremos pastel*, a sensuous act of remembering" (Taidejulkaisutotuus, 2023)



†Figure 36
Guests eating the sculptures
Photo by Radul Radulović



†Figure 37
Guests admiring the edible artworks.
Photo by Radul Radulović

This writing made me think about how in the end the exhibition turned into a small birthday party, even though there was no birthday. Friends and strangers merged into flavor and taste discussions while listening to music in a Sunday evening (Figure 36). Cake became this universal food among guests while at the same time being part of my individual childhood memories. Reflections like the one from Heikkila made me think about how the cakes work as art. As mentioned before, using the gallery space can give the audience a framework to perceive it as art. However, I don't think it automatically makes it art because it is in a gallery space. I believe the cakes are art because I made them, and they embody my personal stories and memories by recreating recipes and reproducing nostalgic flavors. They showcase my artistic skills; each cake was sketched and planned carefully (see Appendix A.8 for sketches), while it also employs my cooking knowledge to craft edible landscapes in different colors. allowing for others to admire my artwork (Figure 37).



†Figure 38
Cake sculptures on white pedestals in Asbestos Art Space
Photo by Radul Radulović



†Figure 39
Cake sculptures on white pedestals in Asbestos Art Space
Photo by Radul Radulović

Chili



Chili, a plant originally from Mexico, along with maize is a staple in the diets of Mexicans from all socioeconomic backgrounds and is also fundamental to our culture. Nowadays, chili can be found in many other cuisines, cultures which didn't have this ingredient originally. The chili is an ingredient found in every Mexican kitchen and most emblematic dishes, even since pre-Hispanic times. For millennia, cultures of Mesoamerica have used chili peppers as a significant part of the everyday life (Cagnato, 2021). There exist different types of chilis that go along with a vast variety of regional cuisines and kitchens. Chilis can be fresh, dried, fermented, filled, crushed or turned into powder. At the same time that there is a diversity of chilis, there is also a variety of flavors within each specific form.

Salsas

To be honest, I've never made a spicy salsa before that is not with *chile guajillo or chile cascabel*. Unfortunately for me, I don't tolerate spiciness very well as it irritates my stomach. However, as I grow older, I'm eating more spicy food and trying to appreciate it more. I cannot deny that my favorite Mexican dishes specifically need this flavourful ingredient. My mom sometimes made some mild salsas for me, she would tell me "*La hice como te gusta, no pica mucho, sólo le da sabor"* (I made it as you like it, it's not too spicy, it just gives some flavor). It is not that I don't like the taste of chili, I love the flavor it can provide, but my body cannot handle it. There are many ways to make salsas, everyone has their own method, preference of ingredients and own unique *sazón*. It also depends on the region and family where you are from. There are an infinite number of salsas in Mexico, but undoubtedly the most celebrated, complex, respectable, and Mexican is *mole*.

The National Dish?

As a child I disliked *mole*, as I mentioned before I couldn't tolerate spicy food at all. I remember trying it once in one of the weekly Sunday family meals we had where cousins, uncles, aunts, grandparents, and friends were invited. I didn't like the taste; my tastebuds couldn't tolerate the spiciness and immediately rejected it. It wasn't until a few years ago that I gave *mole* another chance, and to my surprise I loved it. I started to constantly ask my uncle and mom to cook *mole* for me, they both had their own different recipes and sometimes argued about their cooking choices. My mom always complained on how her brother's *mole* was too watery. I didn't mind both versions, but of course to me, my mother's will always be my favorite one.

As discussed in Chapter 1, *mole* is Mexico's honored national dish, that came from a dark background of colonization and marginalization (Aguilar-Rodríguez, 2018). The *mole* is a syncretism of indigenous and Spanish culture, whose origins are still disputed today. The nuances of chocolate, banana, and raisins that make it sweet, the intensity of the different chilis, nuts, cinnamon, clove, garlic, and pepper, the flavor it adds to the chicken when eaten together, creates a balance of all the ingredients that even though are mixed, exist as their own in this complex brown dish. Even though the *mole* is an entangled dish with political, economic, and cultural uses, it is also a very delicious and relevant symbol that represents national unity as nowadays it can be found almost everywhere (Barros, 2004) (Figure 40).



Figure 40
Mole appears on the cover of a cookbook
Note. From *Lo Mejor de la Cocina Oaxaqueña* [Photograph], 1975 (https://lacocinahistorica.wordpress.com/2013/03/29/lo-mejor-de-la-cocina-oaxaquena-1975-mole-amarillo/)

Not all *moles* are dark, but unquestionably the *mole poblano* from Puebla[17] is the most distinguished and appreciated. The *mole* obtains its intense color due to the chilis it's made from. The true origin of *mole* is still unclear; there are stories related to nuns creating the dish in kitchen convents. Most of these stories have been denied, due to historical facts. I choose to believe the story in which pre-Hispanic indigenous Aztecs mixed different chilis, tomatoes, cacao, and spices to come up with something which they called *mulli*[18] (Barros, 2004). Alonso de Molina (1571) translates the phrase *mulli* to salsa or stew. The term mulli was used to describe a variety of complex dishes with a thick sauce, which later got translated into *mole*. This *mole*, elaborated by Aztecs clashed with ingredients and spices from other parts of the world as product of colonization, becoming into what we know of *mole* today (Barros, 2004). Oaxaca[19] disputes with Puebla for the origins of *mole* as they both have rich variations. In Oaxaca, there exists a diversity of flavors that embrace black *mole*, green *mole*, red *mole*, yellow *mole*, red-brownish *mole*, *manchamanteles,* among others (Pilcher, 2018) (Figure 41). Oaxaca nowadays is considered a cultural epicenter, or as Pilcher recalls "land of seven *moles*" (2018). Oaxaca's biodiversity and cultural richness among indigenous people is translated into its culinary abundance of chilis and dishes. This recognition of only one *mole* internationally ignores all the regional foods and cultures that coexist in Mexico, as *moles* can be found in other places such as Veracruz or Mexico City.



Figure 41
Moles Oaxaqueños, Photo I took from a trip to Oaxaca in 2018.

[17] Puebla is state located in the central highlands of Mexico.
[18] Mulli is a word in Náhuatl, the language of the Aztecs/Mexicas and still spoken today in Mexico.
[19] Oaxaca is a state located in southern Mexico.



Figure 42
Some of the ingredients within the mole.

Months ago, I messaged my mother to ask her for the *mole* recipe she always cooks, she sent me a long list of ingredients, no quantities, and some vague instructions (Figure 42). Even though she shared her recipe with me, it's almost impossible to make a replica of it, as the process of making *mole* is an individual one, where every cook has their own sensory knowledge (Barros, 2004). Thrussell argues that, "The recipe for *mole negro*, as with other dishes, is one that is not usually written down but rather learnt and remembered as described above from one's mother or grandmother through watching and participating in the cooking process" (2016, p. 191). I have never eaten *mole* outside of Mexico and I've never tried to make *mole* before, it's something that only my mother makes. I have observed her on several occasions before, it's a whole ritual and the kitchen turns into a complete mess. I remember the last time she cooked for me, when she was almost finished, she added in more chocolate to adjust the *sazón*, gave me a taste to know what I think. "*Le falta que esté más dulce*" (It needs to be sweeter), I told her. So, she added in more raisins, and plantain. I tried it again with my fingers, it felt perfect, and she believed me.

Mole is usually considered a feast dish by many, there's no other dish that can be at the same ceremonial level as this beautiful brown sauce. Mexicans eat *mole* in weddings, baptisms[20] , first communions, birthdays, and any other important celebration. I've been very privileged, to be able to eat *mole* more than once a year, as my mother cooks it every time I go to visit her. As the *mole* is a complex dish to make, it is rarely made in small quantities, therefore my mother freezes the leftovers to repeat in another occasion in the form of *recalentado*[21] . Every time my mom cooks it, my father opens a sparkling wine bottle, because for him it's a celebration. Even if it's just my parents and siblings in the table, we still celebrate being together and that my mother made the effort to cook something special for us.

[20] As in 2020, 77.77% of Mexico's population identified as catholic, according to the Instituto Nacional de Estadística, Geografía e Informática (INEGI).
[21] It means reheating and eating food from previous days.

Aromas From Home: Cooking Memories Through Complex Salsas

Aromas From Home: Cooking Memories Through Complex Salsas was an edible installation made of objects and salsas where my personal artistic practice unravels through culturally familiar food. Cooking became an embodied process of remembering and exploring my own *sazón*, while eating became a way of sharing my personal identity. The main protagonist was the chili, present in complex salsas that consisted of *mole* (Figure 43), *pipian*, and *salsa tatemada*. The salsas were accompanied with *arroz rojo*, roasted cauliflower, different mushrooms, *tostadas*, tortillas, sour oat cream, and vegan crumbling cheese, as well as hibiscus water to digest.



Figure 43
Arroz rojo, mole, mushroom, and sesame tostadas
Photo by Radul Radulović

The objects on the installation were conformed of earthenware and tablecloths recollected from different recycling centers around Helsinki, objects I brought from Mexico or that my mother sent me, and a handmade embroidered tablecloth. The installation took place during a Sunday afternoon in my friends' garden in Kulosaari, Helsinki.

While making the *mole* I was a bit nervous, I was afraid of doing something for the first time and obtaining something completely different, something that did not resemble the tastes of home. Nevertheless, cooking felt intuitively. I didn't employ exact quantities; I used my body in the whole process. My body as a tool for measuring, for breaking the ingredients. My senses for smelling the home aromas, for tasting the *sazón* and for sensing the correct texture. Making *mole* felt as an organic process, where I knew what to do and adjusted the flavors to my own preferences (Figure 44).

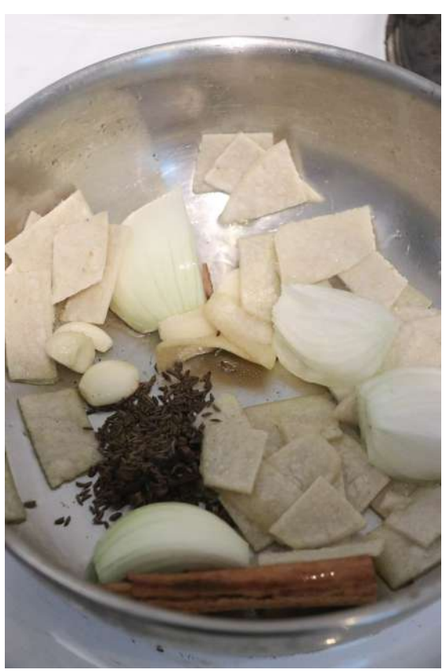


Figure 44
Frying the spices and tortillas.

Besides *mole*, I also made *pipian*, a salsa made with pumpkin seeds (Figure 45 & 46). There are different varieties around Mexico that can include pureed greens, chilis, or tomatillos. In La Huasteca where I am from, *pipian* is a very popular dish and usually not spicy. My mom's *pipian* is very simple yet very tasty, it only includes toasted pumpkin seeds, onion, and garlic.

Finally, the other salsa I made was *salsa tatemada*, a salsa that is not spicy, that also comes from my mom's recipes where all the ingredients are *tatemados* (charred) (Figure 47). My mom prefers this recipe over others because as she chars the ingredients, they become softer on the stomach and don't cause irritation. By cooking this recipe, I take care of my belly.



Figure 45
Adding pumpking seeds to toast in pan.



Figure 46
Blending all the ingredients for pipian.



Figure 47
Charring the ingredients for Salsa Tatemada

I've always loved collecting flowers, it's something that I learned from my *abuelita* Amparo– she would always dry different flowers among her book pages. This is something I've been doing every year, collecting colorful leaves and edible flowers to press among books and use later or keep as seasonal memories. For the tortillas, I did a similar thing, I foraged fireweed flowers, picked nasturtium and coriander leaves from my own indoor garden, and *cempasúchil* (tagetes) bought flowers. Days later, I made a maize *masa* and pressed it down with the array of flowers and greens (Figure 48 & 49). The result was beautiful and unique tortillas, that included memories from Helsinki such as the perennial fireweed (Figure 50 & 51) and *cempasúchil* (Figure 52) , a flower originally from Mexico. Making the tortillas was a slow and exhausting process, where I would press down twice, and then cook in the pan, one by one. The *masa* was very soft and had to be handled delicately, something that I have learned over time.



☥Figure 48
Making a ball of masa
Photo by Radul Radulović



☥Figure 49
Me pressing down the masa
Photo by Radul Radulović



☥Figure 50
Me making tortillas with fireweed and hibiscus infusion
Photo by Radul Radulović



☥Figure 51
Me handling the tortillas with care
Photo by Radul Radulović



☥Figure 52
Me handling the tortilla with care
Photo by Radul Radulović



☥Figure 53
Uncooked black tostadas with sesame seeds
Photo by Radul Radulović

Besides the tortillas, I made some experimental black *tostadas*, my idea behind this was to make something reminiscent of volcanic stone, a wide used material in Mexico. I blended some black sesame and added it to the *masa*, the result was astonishing as the material didn't seem like maize at first glance, and it also provided a sesame taste (Figure 53). I made it with a rolling pin instead of using the tortilla press, which provided for organic forms that I cut by pulling the material from an edge. These *tostadas* were later cooked in a pan, dried, and baked in the oven so they could be crunchy when eaten.

Twenty-two guests came over, some friends and other strangers, once again food brought us together. My friends' garden was perfect as the lush and flowers reminded me of my childhood home. I arranged the *mole* in one corner and the *pipian* in another, with their respective ingredients. The *mole* with the *arroz rojo* and the *pipian* and *salsa tatemada* with the cheese and cream. I also arranged a big table with a bowl of hibiscus water.



Figure 54
Roasted cauliflower, cheese, cream, pipina, mushrooms, tortillas and tostadas
Photo by Radul Radulović



Figure 55
Hibiscus water above embroidered tablecloth
Photo by Radul Radulović



Figure 56
A person grabbing mole with a tostada
Photo by Radul Radulović

At the beginning of the event, I gave a small introduction, explaining the food and how I placed it. I noticed that the guests took a while to start eating, but after they did, they would continually come back to get more food. After people experienced the edible installation, I asked them to write their thoughts or reflections about the experience in a piece of paper (see Appendix C for full reflections transcripts). On each piece of paper, I wrote different words, 'identity', 'memories', 'food'. After eating, people could write their digestions related to one of the words and the experience. The instructions were simple, and I chose this format as it could be a more intimate reflection, most of the writings were anonymous.

Mole and *pipian* are usually eaten with chicken or meat. However, since I moved to Finland, I have changed my eating habits because it is more accessible to have a plant-based diet than when I lived in Mexico. I wanted to include everyone in this experience, which is why the food was vegan and gluten free (Figure 54). While I had strange flavors and spices, I opted for including mushrooms and cauliflowers as a replacement for meat. In a reflection about 'identity' someone wrote:

> "I really loved all the tastes, spices. The mushrooms made me feel like home, that was fascinating to notice. I would love to bring food closer to my identity, right now it feels hard to connect it. That was my realization from the event. I would love to search which food/dishes strengthen my identity, also dishes outside of Finnish food culture".

From what I have experienced, mushrooms are a big part of Finnish food culture. Foraging mushrooms is a special experience and cooking them too. This person found a link between my identity and theirs through mushrooms. This food served as a way to experience different food through their own individual identities that belong to a collective one (Le Breton, 2017).

Besides the previous extract, other people also pointed out how identity was intertwined with food in this installation. A participant wrote:

> "being in this exhibition reminds me how food brings so much identity to us... being an Indian in a foreign landscape, all this sensorial experience of either being alone or together in a community helps us as a good reminder to our good times together or alone in our home countries and keep it alive. To add to this time cooked, the order of presentation and the formation of ingredients in a dish helps us recall our identities"

This person as I, moved from her home country to Finland. As she writes about this experience that reminded her of previous moments in India, I can't help but think about how food can serve as a connector to home, not only for me, but also for people experiencing my artworks (Figure 57).



Figure 57
Guests eating and getting to know each other
Photo by Radul Radulović



Figure 58
Holding the food with the hands adds to the multisensorial experience
Photo by Radul Radulović

It was also fascinating to see how several people pointed out about how they experienced this installation through their senses, further affirming how food can be multisensorial (Figure 57). A friend wrote:

> "How we even identify to our senses is sometimes through food. We associate with our senses through food, example: how it tastes, how it smells, how it feels in your hands, how it sounds in your mouth— the crunchiness, the gullible soft food etc.... and how the food looks"

The senses help us make senses of our experiences and digest our surroundings (Le Breton, 2017). Food gets into our body and becomes something else when digested. "Sight. Taste. Smell. Texture/Touch. It gets into you, and it becomes you". Food is digested and makes us who we are.

Besides food being intertwined with my identity, food can also be many other things:

> "Food as caring. Food as sharing. Food as contaminating: some of your taste is now in my palate. We can never know if you see things the same way, if we taste food the same. Food for waiting. Food for socializing. Food as an excuse to get to know others"

This reflection fascinated me, it made me think how food can be many things at the same time, and how my energy, love, and care through cooking the food for the installation got perceived and appreciated (Thrussell, 2016).

Food can be an artistic medium and a vehicle for meeting new people, a means to engage in conversation with strangers. Someone wrote: "*Compartir un mismo espacio y tiempo (momento) Intercambiar*". (Share the same space and time [moment]. An exchange). And other person wrote: "I think it's a delicious and exciting way to invite people to share something more than just an aesthetic experience. We didn't know each other before but I feel like I am part of something". The edible installation became a space for sharing memories, identity, flavors, likes and dislikes, and even recipes. In a reflection, someone wrote their "Mum's plum cake recipe", which made me very happy to see, how this installation also became a space for exchanging knowledge.



Figure 59
Guests eating
Photo by Radul Radulović

Back at home, my mom frequently uses large earthenware pots to cook and serve food, it tastes different (Figure 60). While here in Finland I cannot cook with earthenware pots due to almost all homes having induction stoves, I thought of still trying to find earthenware to serve the food and impregnate the food with the earth colors. In a writen reflection about 'memories' someone wrote the following:

> *"Mi mama solo usaba la vajilla de barro cuando había comidas en el jardín e invitábamos a toda la familia. Los cubiertos suenan diferente cuando comes con platos de barro, raspan el material de manera diferente y recuerdo muy bien ese sonido todavía".* (My mother only used earthenware when we had meals in the garden, and we invited the whole family. The cutlery sounds different when you eat with clay dishes, they scrape the material differently and I still remember that sound very well).

It was interesting to see that this person wrote a memory from home, a memory that I can also relate to. Earthenware reminds me of home, and just like this person narrates, I can also still hear the sound of the cutlery scraping a clay pot.



Figure 60
My mom cooking rice in a clay pot over a wood stove.

Besides collecting earthenware objects from recycling centers, different tablecloths were gathered. I incorporated these fabrics together with textiles from home and a tablecloth I hand embroidered with all the ingredients within *mole*. The mix of fabrics, each representing a distinct origin and history, symbolized the complexities and significance inherent in the food as well as in my complex identity. The interplay of the ceremonial and nostalgic feeling of lace with the personal touch of handwritten pieces resulted in a visually fascinating tapestry that interweaved memories and cultural identity. By creating

an installation made of merged objects I brought from home and objects that reminded me of home, I'm reconstructing and redefining my personal identity as a Mexican woman living in Finland.

With this installation, I presented how my personal identity unravels through my artistic practice. I chose certain salsas that gave me emotional comfort and reminded me of the flavors from home (Figure 61 & 62). By cooking recipes such as *mole*, I asserted my own *sazón* that is part of my personal identity. The *mole,* a dish that is usually prepared in a celebratory context, allowed me to recreate memories in a new cultural context, with new meaning as well (Figure 63). This provided me comfort and curiosity about how others experienced the food and related or felt disconnected to this experience.



☥Figure 61
A guest grabbing a tortilla, behind the salsa tatemada



☥Figure 62
A guest grabbing salsa tatemada
Photo by Radul Radulović



☥Figure 63
Food laying over a pedestal in the garden
Photo by Radul Radulović

Sobremesa

At the beginning of this thesis, my research was framed around how I could use my own identity and memories to explore food as an artistic medium. In the process, I have now discovered how it is also through food that I create new memories that add to my constantly changing identity. Along this path of self-discovery, I have learned more about myself through memories, food stories, and personal narratives. Through untangling my surrounding context, I have created edible landscapes that illustrate my *sazón*, memories, and identity.

The theoretical framework helped me untangle the intricate connection between food, identity, memories, and the senses. Acknowledging the inherent sensorial nature of food, I have used food as a way to sense the world, to build relationships, and to craft narratives that build my personal identity. At the same time, I have come to understand how food can build personal identities and collective ones. This comprehensive theoretical background has also made me realize some ways in which food can be understood and experienced as art, which later helped me to craft my own artistic works.

By exploring the intersection of food and art, this thesis has affirmed how food is a powerful artistic medium through the different dimensions explored within this work. First, food has a personal meaning because of its significance and connection to my personal experiences from home. Secondly, food has a cultural meaning because some of the ingredients and foods that I explored are part of my personal identity that belongs to a collective cultural identity. Within its cultural meaning, food also has a historical meaning as it involves practices and embodied knowledge that has been passed down through generations, as well originating from historical events. Thirdly, food has a sensorial meaning because it can engage all our senses, not only when eaten but also when preparing and sourcing for ingredients. And lastly, food has emotional meaning, because cooking is my love language and I express my feelings through my food.

This research makes a valuable contribution to the intersection of food and art by researching, exploring and materializing the potential of food as an artistic medium, from my personal perspective as a Mexican contemporary designer living in Finland. By delving into the personal, cultural, sensorial, and emotional dimensions of food, this research reveals how it can be used to evoke memories, emotions, and communicate personal narratives. This work belongs to the growing interest between food and art, not only from an academic research point of view but also between artists and designers. This interest also corresponds to an increment in the appreciation of art through food, with artists like Laila Gohar, who made up a career from working with food as a medium and opened a gateway for others to follow along.

Overall, this thesis has not only shed light on the artistic potential of food but has also illuminated the profound role it plays in our everyday lives, where food as an artistic medium can also be found through everyday cooking. Through the three artistic installations that explored maize, chili, and cakes I have revealed certain ways in which food can serve as an artistic medium through my own food culture, food stories, and food narratives. This is not to say that these are the only ways, food as an artistic medium fascinates me, as it is a world of possibilities that does not seem to ever end.

Edible Landscapes: Food as an Artistic Medium is just the beginning of my practice as a contemporary designer. This research work helped me define my own narrative, practice and with this, my own *sazón*. As I mentioned before, I'm very excited to keep exploring this new world where design, art, and food can come together in an exciting cross disciplinary medium.

(Conclusions)

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This thesis would have never been possible without the support and love from my parents and family. Particular thanks to my *abuelitas* Amparo and Nely, and my mom Patricia, whose memories and stories inspire me every day and their teachings live throughout my cooking and artworks.

This was a very long journey where I learned the patience, care, and time food needs in order to be made. Although it may not seem like it, there was a lot of time, energy, and help from others in the preparation beforehand and work put to make the food on time before each installation. My deepest thanks go to Radul Radulović, who helped me all along the way, from documenting my process with photos, to aiding me in any way possible and motivating me to keep going.

Special thanks to my friends, who also helped me through my thesis process and for their valuable emotional support. Thank you for believing in what I do and for assisting to multiple of my installations without knowing what to expect. Finally, I'm very grateful with my advisor Ayshé Jenkinson, for encouraging me to continually unpick and to grow my thinking boundaries. Also, very grateful with my supervisor Julia Lohmann for her enthusiasm and help.



Recetario

Below are written some recipes that I included in my research. Not all of the recipes have clear measurements or instructions, as they are learned recipes that my body remembers, and that my body relearns each time I make them.

Mole

Ingredients:
Pumpkin seeds
Almonds
Peanuts
Sesame seeds

Dry chilis:
Chile ancho
Chile mulato
Chile pasilla
Chile chipotle
Chile cascabel
Chile guajillo

(It's okay if some are missing but preferably don't omit the chile chipotle).

Spices:
Clove
Pepper
Sugar
Salt
Cumin
Cinnamon
Nutmeg (add at the end)

Other:
Garlic
Onion
Tomato
Raisins
Dark chocolate
Plantain
Tortillas

Instructions:
Devein the chilis by removing all the seeds, wash them well and boil them with water, let them cool and grind them in the blender. Strain the chilis so there are no big chunks and set aside.

Roast all seeds except sesame seeds (they can get bitter and need to be roasted at the end.)

Fry in a bit of oil the onion, garlic, pepper, cinnamon and all the other spices, as well as a couple of tortillas, raisins, and plantain. You can also place the chocolate, so it melts a bit, and it gets easier to blend.

Blend the seeds and fried spices with water, veggie stock or chicken stock. I prefer using water as it lasts longer in the fridge without spoiling. Add salt.

Carefully add the chili mixture to the previous mixture. You can taste until it has the spiciness you like best. Blend everything together again and add nutmeg at the end. Adjust to your own sazón. If you prefer a sweeter taste add more roasted raisins or sugar.

Boil in low temperature and mix constantly to avoid it sticking to the pan. Toast a bit of sesame seeds and sprinkle on top when serving.



(Recipes)

Pipian

Ingredients:
Roasted pumpking seeds
White onion
Garlic (a little)
Salt
Coriander (optional)

Instructions:
Roast the pumpkin seeds and blend in all the ingredients with a bit of water. Boil for a few minutes in medium temperature, stiring constantly so the pipian doesn't jump around a lot.

Salsa Tatemada

Ingredients:
A bunch of tomatoes
A couple of chilis
Half an onion
A garlic clove
Salt
Coriander

Instructions:
Char all the ingredients in a pan with a bit of oil. Mix everything in the blender. Add salt and a bit of coriander. Boil for a few minutes in low temperature. Enjoy when it cools down.

Pastel de Chocolate (Chocolate cake)

Cocoa mix:
57gr butter (or a bit more)
1 cup of cocoa (or a bit more, depends on the cocoa richness)

Ingredients:
227gr butter (room temperature, soft)
400gr sugar (or a bit less, depends on your taste)
2 cups of buttermilk
4 eggs
480gr flour
3 teaspoons of baking soda
2 teaspoons of vanilla extract

First, add the cocoa mix ingredients in a small saucepan. Melt in low heat and add more butter and a bit of water if needed. The mix needs to be soft enough to later mix with the rest of ingredients
.
Cream the butter and sugar. Add eggs one at a time. Alternate the flour mixed with the baking soda and the buttermilk. If the texture is too thick, add more buttermilk. Incorporate the cocoa mix and add vanilla extract. Bake until ready.



Pastel de Vainilla (Vanilla cake)

Ingredients:
339gr butter (room temperature, soft)
400gr sugar
4 eggs
480gr flour
8 teaspoons baking powder
2 cups of milk
2 teaspoons of vanilla extract

Instructions:
Cream the butter and sugar. Add eggs one at a time. Alternate the flour mixed with the baking powder and the milk. If the texture is too thick, add more milk. Add the vanilla extract. Bake until ready.



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Figure 8
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Figure 9
Bernal del Río, F. (1967). *El Mole* [Painting]. Museo Nacional de Arte INBA. https://www.facebook.com/photo/?fbid=595969789243293&set=a.548030754037197&paipv=0&eav=AfZIZQOQynz3ciZO-n71rt95rQuYYYW8T47vf-bSzCAPYfuBnoaGhinluL3zwX7Mi8M&_rdr

Figure 11
City Foodsters. (2015). *Dish of greens. Some of the vegetables are grilled. Some are fresh. And others have been lightly salted. The plate beneath has been brushed with a paste made of dry scallops* [Photograph]. Flickr https://www.flickr.com/photos/cityfoodsters/19259696676/in/photostream/

Figure 12
David Zwirner Hong Kong gallery. (1990). *Untitled (pad thai) at Paula Allen Gallery* [Photograph]. https://www.tatlerasia.com/lifestyle/arts/how-is-rirkrit-tiravanija-pad-thai-art

Figure 13
Art Basel. (2015). *Do we Dream Under the Same Sky* [Photograph]. https://www.schirn.de/en/magazine/whats_cooking/vom_atelier_an_den_esstisch_rirkrit_tiravanija/

Figure 14
City of Los Angeles Department of Cultural Affairs (DCA). (2019). *Eva Aguila's project Comida a Mano at the Reseda Recreation Center, part of the 2019 "Current: LA" biennial* [Photograph]. https://www.artnews.com/art-news/artists/art-food-collaborations-vaginal-davis-rirkrit-tiravanija-1234603683/

Figure 15
City of Los Angeles Department of Cultural Affairs (DCA). (2019). *Chef Maria Ornelas at work* [Photograph]. https://www.artnews.com/art-news/artists/art-food-collaborations-vaginal-davis-rirkrit-tiravanija-1234603683/

Figure 16
(n.d.). *A range of Dubois desserts from Cuisine Classique emphasising display and consumption* [Photograph]. https://www.architectural-review.com/essays/let-them-eat-cake-urbain-dubois

Figure 17
Villa Eugenie. (2019). *Shrimp and langoustine tower* [Photograph] https://lailagohar.com/langoustine-tower/

Figure 18
Gohar, L. (n.d). *Hay Sobremesa Launch* [Photograph] https://lailagohar.com/hay-sobremesa-launch/

Figure 19
Gohar, L. (n.d). *UFO table* [Photograph] https://lailagohar.com/ufo-table/

Figure 20
Burton, K. (2019). *"Frutas y Verduras" for Ananas Ananas Launch Party* [Photograph]. Metal Magazine. https://metalmagazine.eu/en/post/interview/ananas-ananas

Figure 21
Molina, P. (2020). *Extraños* [Photograph]. By Metal Magazine. https://metalmagazine.eu/en/post/interview/ananas-ananas

Figure 22
Abu Dhabi Art. (2022). *Tropical Anthology* [Photograph]. https://caiquetizzi.com/

Figure 23
Abu Dhabi Art. (2022). *Tropical Anthology* [Photograph]. https://caiquetizzi.com/

Figure 31
Limbo. (2006). *Región Huasteca en México* [Illustration]. Wikipedia. https://es.wikipedia.org/wiki/Regi%C3%B3n_Huasteca#/media/Archivo:Regi%C3%B3n_Huasteca.png

Figure 33- 39
Photo by Radul Radulović (2023)

Figure 40
(1975). *Lo Mejor de la Cocina Oaxaqueña* [Photograph]. https://lacocinahistorica.wordpress.com/2013/03/29/lo-mejor-de-la-cocina-oaxaquena-1975-mole-amarillo/

Figure 43
Photo by Radul Radulović (2023)

Figure 48-59
Photo by Radul Radulović (2023)

Figure 62-63
Photo by Radul Radulović (2023)

Appendix

A. Process documentation

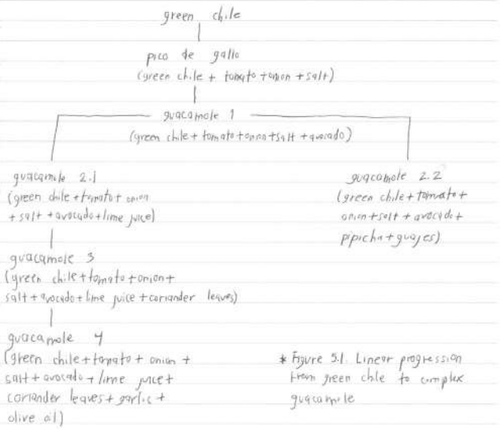
A.1

December 1st 2022 —— *food diary*
Making chocolate cake

I'm waiting for the chocolate cake to finish baking. I've been thinking about baking a cake all week, specially this one. My recipe was from my mom, and she took it from her mom. It has buttermilk in it, making the cake extra moist. It's weird because in Mexico we can't buy buttermilk in supermarkets, you have to make it. While in Finland the milk section is filled up with an infinite of ~~dairy~~ yogurty products.
I'm mainly baking this cake because of the buttermilk... I had some leftovers from the last time I made a cake & I hate food going to waste.
This time, while mixing the ingredients I added something new: miso. I don't know if it will taste because the chocolate flavor can be very strong. Also while mixing I played with the quantities, I wonder if the form and flavor will turn out good.
Meanwhile the whole apartment smells only like chocolate cake.

Culinary art & anthropology — Joy Adapon page 103

Following Gell's theory of art, an artwork (or salsa, in this case) should be thought of as just like a person. It has relations with other persons (salsas), it can 'marry' and 'have offsprings', and thus forms a lineage.



* Figure 3.1. Linear progression from green chile to complex guacamole

A.2

Achiote

Achiote (Bixa orellana L.) is a plant native to tropical America, probably to the Amazon basin in Brazil. It is widely cultivated in all tropical regions around the world; specifically in Colombia, Mexico, Ecuador, and in the Peruvian Andes. (Reference in zotero)

09/12/22

Tortillas with Naturelo flour

It feels weird making tortillas with ~~it~~ corn flour and not with masa, how it's supposed to be.
The measurements is almost 1:1 flour and warm water but I would say using a bit less water than flour and a dash of salt. Because it's winter and the heaters are on the dough dries up very fast.
First I tried to use the rolling pin and plastic wrap to roll the dough, which works perfectly. For a moment I forget that I'm working with food and it feels as if I was rolling a sheet of clay — very similar texture.
My hands help all along the process, they feel a bit dry but feeling the dough and shaping it is very easy.

I tried to dilute some achiote paste in water to paint in my dough canvas which of course didn't work out since the dough is water and flour — it just blended in with the dough.
After this I tried mixing the achiote water with corn flour and it turned into a ~~pink~~ pale pink dough.

I ~~shaped~~ made a little nature inspired shape and put it on top of a white dough square I had. Then I passed the rolling pin on top to merge both shapes — the square cracked a bit but it didn't look that bad.

Because I wanted to experiment with colors and textures I added a bit of turmeric powder to the white dough, to see how much the color changed —

A.3

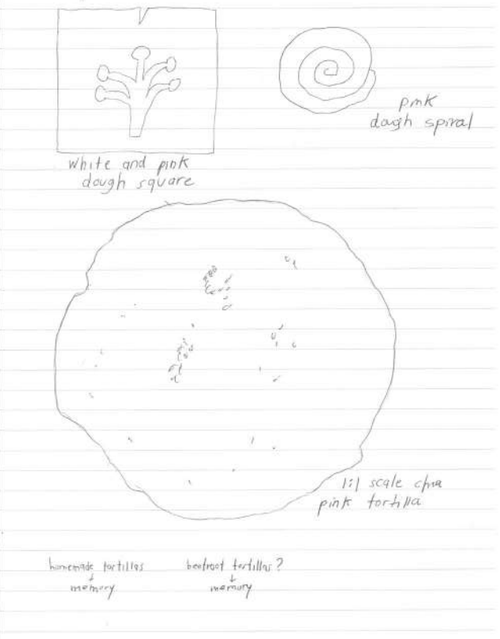
it was a slight yellow. I brought a tortilla press with me from Mexico, a very indispensable ~~tool~~ tool, very necessary for making nice tortillas. My mom urged me to bring this with me last time I visited Mexico, and she was not wrong. This heavy metal tool facilitates a lot the tortilla making process. So I put a small quantity of pink and white-turmeric dough and pressed down — the result was an abstract pattern and also completely random.

I then thought of adding some texture to a tortilla so I got some chia seeds, added them to the dough and pressed down. It is fun to see the outcome of the different elements being pressed all together.
The only negative thing to ~~these~~ this metal tool is that the shape will always come roundish — not exactly a negative thing but a shape limitation.

Afterwards I thought of continuing with the hand building so I made a little coil with the pink dough, ~~it~~ and then turned it into a little spiral.

I cooked all the final shapes and some tortillas even puffed up while cooking in the pan —— that's a good sign.

Some tortillas with chia seeds had some really nice ~~drying~~ drying textures that I appreciated. I would like to try with beetroot next time, as my mom sometimes did ~~to~~ ~~to~~ in ~~hide~~ an attempt to make our breakfast healthier. She would make beetroot and amaranth tortillas, which didn't taste bad at all even though I cannot tolerate the intense flavor of the beetroot.



A.4

12/12/22

Salsa tatemada

I called my mother to ask how she made her salsas, she gave me all the basic knowledge like chilli combinations, spicy intensity and tips on how to make salsas. She knows I suffer from stomach problems so she suggested me to try the salsa tatemada because according to my dad, from who I inherited the belly problems, it ~~the~~ goes gentle on the stomach thanks to the burning of the ingredients.
Tatemada from the verb tatemar and from the nahuatl word tlatemati means "to burn", put on the fire" a synonym for tatemar could be ~~roast~~ asar (roast), ~~But in Mexico we say tatemar los chiles (Burn the chilies)~~ but it is not the same. Tatemar slightly roasts the chillies, tomatoes, onion, and garlic on the outside. In Mexico almost all forms of cooking are by gas, ~~cooking in an intense fire in the stove which makes it easier to tatemar the~~ broiled ingredients by placing them directly in the stove flame,

There are many ways to make salsas, everyone has their own method, preference of ingredients and ~~of~~ their own unique sazón.

I bought ~~a red~~ some spicy chillies in my local supermarket for this salsa tatemada. Fresh chillie salsas are good with tomato, onion and garlic as a base. If the chilis are not fresh then they are good just with onion and garlic. I used an old pan to tatemar my chili, a half a small onion, and a clove of garlic and a few cherry tomatos that I had in my kitchen.

The smell of burning chili reminded me of home.. I then proceeded to blend it all, addesome salt and a few fresh coriander leaves and stem. ~~Afterwards I~~ Afterwards with a little olive oil I fried the salsa for a few minutes to cook it very well so it lasts longer in the fridge.

To be honest I've never made a salsa before that is not with guajillo or cascabel chili before. I don't tolerate spicyness very well and it irritates my stomach sometimes however, as I grow older I'm eating more spicy food and trying to enjoy it more. My mom sometimes made some mild salsas for me and I really enjoyed them. It is not that I don't like the taste of chili, ~~I enjoy~~ but ~~my~~ its body cannot handle it, turning the spicyness into pain ~~for my mouth~~ thus not enjoying the food if it's too spicy.

ingredients

1 red chili
½ onion
1 garlic clove
tomato
salt

mild tatemada salsa
↓
memory

A.5

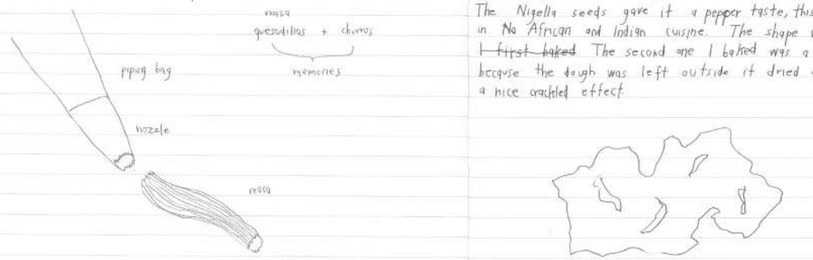
12/01/23

quesadillas → nozzled masa

My mom would sometimes make deep fried quesadillas for breakfast I loved it! I will try to experiment with the shapes and hopefully it wont fall apart. I'm curious to see which shapes I'm able to do? I'm in with the masa and mozarella cheese.

It is very hard to work with masa, it crumbles and dries up too fast, it doesn't feel like the one at home.
I thought of extruding some masa and it worked fine, however when trying to cook it the s texture got lost completely.
It is harder than working with clay.

with the airfryer it worked well (texture remains) but not so tasty and a lot of cracks — looks dry. Maybe the oven could also work



A thought 13/01/23

Something that I've been thinking a lot about is how cooking without an audience, without people to eat it feels weird... empty. I like cooking by myself, experimenting on my own but then when it comes to serving the food I have no one. Either I cook for someone or concentrate on experimenting and documenting

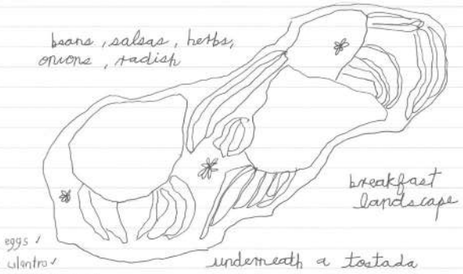
Sculptural tostadas 16/01/2023

Today I experimented with large "tostadas" and it turned out pretty nice. I bought some Nigella seed to add to the dough as well as poppy seeds. I extended the dough in between two sheets of baking paper so it wouldn't stick to the roll pin and it turned out smoothly. I rolled it pretty thin and baked in 180c for about 25min.
The Nigella seeds gave it a pepper taste, this seed is used in No African and Indian cuisine. The shape was very interesting. ~~I first baked~~ The second one I baked was a bit thinner and because the dough was left outside it dried up a lot and had a nice crackled effect

A.6

breakfast edible landscape 1

- pumpkin seeds
- zuchini



- eggs ✓
- cilantro ✓
- pickled onions ✓
- beans ✓
- cream ✓
- guacamole sauce?
- mushrooms?
- quelites radish ✓
- lettuce ✓
- salsa roja ✓
- cheese feta ✓

tostada with charcoal

— the wet ingredients will not ~~make~~ keep it crunchy



mango
passionfruit

things to do
- ✓ limpiar mesa
- o make tostadas
- o cortar rabanos
- ✓ rebajar crema
- o calentar frijoles

✓ lavar tomates y cilantro
o hacer huevos

A.7

Saturday display



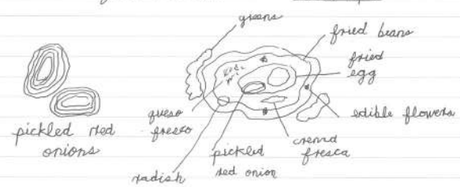


big tostada — would it fit in the oven?



tostadas to hold the food + to eat

tostada layers



Remember the garden back at home

A.8

1. crema/amarillo/violeta

26"

4.5"

chocolate cake
buttercream de coco
curd de maracuyá

pansies, carambolo, uchuva, rosehip, polvo lila

2. beige/crema/café

8"

chocolate cake
buttercream de cajeta
ganache de chocolate

chocolate shavings, cocoa powder, polvo chai

3. verde/rosa

8"

vainilla cake
mascarpone de matcha
fresas

frambuesas frescas y deshidratadas, salvia, romero, polvo verde o de matcha

4. crema/morado/azul

6"

vainilla cake
butter cream de vainilla
mermelada frutos rojos

pansies, polvo de blueberry, zarzamora, hojas de betabel, acigno azul

5. verde

lemon cupcakes
mascarpone de vainilla con colorante verde

salvia ensalada

A.9

instalación mole complex mole
complex salsas seasoning my life

vasijas con plantas de chiles

how? clay pots + tableware made of earthenware mole, pipian, salsas

where? outdoors environment why? it is a shared experience where everyone is invited & the sitting around the table is small

why? • share some of my favorite dishes that play an important part of mexicos national identity and showcase the complexity of a dish & the meaning it can carry
• combining my design background with cooking
• carrying memories through remembering & crafting objects with meaning. Just like food, objects around us also have an origin and purpose. → following my memories to cook

→ should I add the cakes?
→ make questions?

community
a way to come closer to the other
eating together
mole
daily dish
identity
cooking with my
memories
recipe
learnt & remembered
new memory
embodied act of cooking
¿qué comida extraño?
Multi
¿qué aroma me transporta al hogar?
en mi mero mole
compartir es crecer
es que lo hice con amor I cook
¿yo soy un mole?
how is food linked to my identity?
todas las semillas se tuestan pero el ajonjolí ~~al final~~ si se excede amargo
Is it that I feel more mexican when im abroad?
sin cantidades o medidas ~~hacer sazón~~

A.10

06 july

pipian mom's Recipe

pepitas tostadas	roasted pumpkin seeds
cebolla blanca	white onion
ajo (un poco)	garlic (a little)
se tuestan las pepitas y se muelen con cebolla y ajo, poner a hervir	toast the pumpkin seeds & blend in with the onion & garlic, boil everything together
se puede agregar cilantro	you can add coriander
pipian rojo — agregar chile guajillo	red pipian — add chile guajillo

Hacer
To make this recipe without measurements felt natural, even though I had never made it before.
The hardest part is to be patient, partion when toasting the pumpking seeds as they can burn. You need to stay by the stove, not go away. The rest is simple, it is just three ingredients.
I have eaten this dish many times back at my hometown, I only eat it there.

07 july

Aromas from home

where to serve earthenware + big plates

community
a way to come closer to the other
cooking with my
recipe
mole
mulli = salsa
complex but also daily
learnt & remembered
memories
identity
Menu
recreating new memory worlds
my food culture
- tortillas + tostadas
- mole — arroz rojo?
- pipian
- salsa taterada
- protein { mushrooms(oyster) with garlic / cauliflower - roasted
- queso & crema fresca
- hibiscus ~~&~~ water
- flowers

B.1 *Queremos Pastel:* A Sensuous Act of Remembering exhibition poster.



B.1 *Aromas From Home:* Cooking Memories Through Complex Salsas exhibition poster.



C.1 Memories

1. "Eating with my hands + this type of food that allows for playful combination connected me to my childhood and playful side. *Al no ser un tipo de comida que haya sido una constante en ningún momento de mi vida, estos sabores principalmente me recuerdan a los momentos en los que tú me cocinaste y mostraste tu gastronomía y tus recuerdos familiares a través de los platos*"

2. "Friendship"

3. "*Mi mama solo usaba la vajilla de barro cuando había comidas en el jardín e invitábamos a toda la familia. Los cubiertos suenan diferente cuando comes con platos de barro, raspan el material de manera diferente y recuerdo muy bien ese sonido todavía*"

C.2 Food

1. "It gets into you and it becomes you. Food as caring. Food as sharing. Food as contaminating: some of your taste is now in my palate. We can never know if you see things the same way, if we taste food the same. Food for waiting. Food for socializing. Food as an excuse to get to know others. Mum's Plum cake (without plums): 2 eggs, 200gr flour, 120gr milk, 80gr olive oil, 70gr sugar, pinch of salt, lemon and orange zest, 16gr baking powder... fruit, chow, etc. As you prefer."

2. "*Compartir un mismo espacio y tiempo (momento) Intercambiar. Recordar. Conocer. Viajar. Volver a casa pero distinto*"

3. "I think it's a delicious and exciting way to invite people to share something more than just an aesthetic experience. We didn't know each other before but I feel like I am part of something. Thank you for the food!"

C.3 Identity

1. "Being in this exhibition reminds me how food brings so much identity to us. How we even identify to our senses is sometimes through food. We associate with our senses through food, example: how it tastes, how it smells, how it fuels in your hands, how it sounds in your mouth- the crunchiness, the gullible soft food etc... and also how the food looks. Being an Indian in a foreign landscape, all this sensorial experience either being alone or together in a community helps us as a good reminder to our good times together or alone in our home countries and keep it alive. To add to this even time cooked, the order of presentation and the formation of ingredients in a dish helps us recall our identities. In a similar way, this exhibition gives you a holistic experiences of the senses that you can identify with Mexican food"

2. "*Que rico y un poco sorprendente. Una finlandesa se piensa que se sabe que es comida mexicana pero la verdad es que no tiene muy poca idea. Yo, personalmente tengo una relación un poco rara con comida. Lo agradezco mucho, una vez en como dos meses amo cocinar pero normalmente solamente como para tener mi estómago lleno. Y luego, cuando como de la mano de alguien a quien le encanta el cocinar me recuerda que lindo es ese arte*"

3. "I really loved all the tastes, spices. The mushrooms made me feel like home, that was fascinating to notice. I would love to bring food closer to my identity, right now it feels hard to connect it. That was my realization from the event. I would love to search which food/dishes strengthen my identity, also dishes outside of Finnish food culture."

4. "After a long time struggling relationship with food, it is actually nice to just enjoy and taste all the flavors, and enjoy also the social experience with food. The experience how the food feels like and not think about the nutrients and calories or something. Crunch and flavors"